

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF
MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

SUNDAY 11 OCTOBER 2026 · THE WEEKEND EDITION



THREE THOUSAND FIVE HUNDRED AND FORTY METRES TO AN ISLAND OF SIX THOUSAND PEOPLE (P22)

THE TRAVEL DESK

Two in three of Japan's typhoons come here. The school holidays sit in the trough

Twelve Desks · One World

THE RABBIT HOLE

In Singapore the pushed board has more legal path access than the electric one

THE ATELIER

The good toe costs about a dollar. The word the trade uses may mean the cheap one

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THE SPINE: the toll — what is charged for permission, and how rarely it matches the thing

FROM THE DESK

“For my part, I travel not to go anywhere, but to go. I travel for travel’s sake. The great affair is to move.”
Robert Louis Stevenson, *Travels with a Donkey in the Cévennes* (1879), “Cheylard and Luc”¹
Nothing on this cover charges a toll: the bridge is free. A category abolished by the very tax that invented it. A category abolished by the very tax that invented it. A hundred dollars for a strap. The spine is **the toll** — what gets charged for permission, and how seldom it matches the thing.

THE STRIP • AT FRIDAY’S CLOSE		
US 2-year	4.80%	▼ 3bp
US 10-year	5.24%	▼ 4bp
VWRA	\$193.50	▲ 0.39%
Global agg	\$5.731	▲ 0.10%
DXY	102.21	▲ 0.27%
USD/SGD	1.2804	flat
Brent	\$104.72	▲ 2.42%
Gold, COMEX	\$4,216.30	▲ 1.30%
Bitcoin	\$82,546	▼ 2.31%

Friday to Friday; 10 October was a Saturday. The Straits Times Index closed 5,401.89, down 4.13% on the week (p14). Not advice.²

FROM THE ARCHIVE • NO. 79, 22 AUGUST 2026

We flagged the route before it existed. The Yaeyama deep dive of No. 79 noted in passing that reaching the far south was “newly easier since Scoot goes five-times-weekly to Naha from 31 October”. That date is now three weeks away.³

It also made a correction we are still living off. No. 79 pointed out that a resort routinely listed as a Yaeyama option is actually on Irabu, in the Miyako islands — “a different group, with its own flights”. That distinction is why this weekend’s Grand Tour can go to Miyako without repeating itself (p21).³

And it held a line we can now improve on. That issue declined to name a single restaurant on the islands because the local review platforms could not be read: “a fabricated address is worse than none.” Seven weeks on, this desk can at least read a public market’s own opening hours — and still prints no fare for the flight (p22).³

SOURCES 1 Robert Louis Stevenson, *Travels with a Donkey in the Cévennes*, first published 1879; the passage is quoted from the chapter “Cheylard and Luc”, read in the 1907 Chatto & Windus impression digitised by Project Gutenberg. The sentences continue: “to feel the needs and hitches of our life more nearly; to come down off this feather-bed of civilisation, and find the globe granite underfoot and strewn with cutting flints.” 2 Levels as set out on the Macro Desk, from the United States Treasury’s own par yield series and one provider’s exchange feeds; that single-provider dependence is stated there. 3 This magazine’s own No. 79 of 22 August 2026, read in the archive.

THE WORLD · DIESEL & SANCTIONS

One official switched the dollar off, then on

At 2.43pm in Washington on Friday, the same director who had just listed an international court authorised the import of Russian diesel. Both measures run 180 days.

The document is two paragraphs long, signed **Bradley T. Smith**, Director of the Office of Foreign Assets Control, at **14:43:59** eastern time on **Friday 9 October. General Licence No. 135** authorises **“the sale, delivery, offloading, or importation, including importation into the United States, of diesel fuel of Russian Federation origin”**, and runs **“through 12:01 a.m. ... April 7, 2027”**. One carve-out: no debits to Russia’s central bank, wealth fund or finance ministry.¹

The same office, under the same action date, had just placed the **International Criminal Court** on the sanctions list. We printed that yesterday. What we could not see yesterday is the symmetry: both instruments run **180 days**, and one afternoon carries both.²

The volumes came by post: **“over 300,000 tons”** at once, **500,000** in November, **a million** after that, up to **three million** if refineries allow. Moscow moved on Saturday, the cabinet partially lifting its own export ban on the identical ladder.³

The reason is on the forecourt. American retail diesel averaged **US\$6.2824** a gallon on 10 October against **\$3.6732** a year earlier — **up 71 per cent**. Refined product, not crude, is what broke. The announcement took **2.96 per cent** off the diesel contract on Friday; it still finished the week **up 5.27 per cent**.⁴

Then the politics detonated. On Saturday the President told Ukraine to stop striking Russian refineries — **“So he better damn well stop”** — and added: **“I think it’s time for Ukraine to get a new president.”** President Zelensky had called the licence **“a weak decision by our strong partners”**, and after a daytime missile attack wrote: **“The consequences**

of allowing Russia to sell oil products were most clearly felt in Kyiv today.”⁵

MOSCOW

TASS

Treaty-keeping, not a favour. The decision is **“aimed at implementing the agreements reached”** by the two presidents, and Russian consumers are untouched. Friday’s call ran about **an hour and a half** — the sixteenth since early 2025.⁶

KYIV

THE KYIV INDEPENDENT

A transfer of money to the enemy, felt the same day. Its own reporting is blunter than its quotations: Ukraine **“was blindsided”** and **“it felt like a trap”**. Kyiv will stop striking Russian energy if Russia stops striking Ukraine’s. Moscow has not taken it up.⁵

THE CHATTER · HELPFUL, NOT A NEEDLE-MOVER

Dan Pickering of Pickering Energy Partners does the sum: **“perhaps a 5–6% increase in supply between now and year end”**, which he calls **“more politics than a game changer”**. **Gregory Brew** of Eurasia Group: **“a bandaid, nothing more”**, and Putin **“expects Ukraine to cease its attacks on refineries in exchange”**.⁷

THE SCEPTIC · A DAY AND A HALF OF LUNCH

Take October and November together — **800,000 tonnes**, roughly **six million barrels**. America burns about **3.7 million barrels of diesel a day**, so the announcement is **thirty-six hours** of consumption. Worse: Russian diesel exports fell from **850,000 barrels a day** in the first quarter to **190,000** in the third, and Russia *imported* diesel this quarter. **Richard Nephew**, once of the State Department: **“the damage it does to the broader sanctions regime is very significant.”**⁸

The instrument is real even if the barrels are small.

SOURCES 1 General Licence No. 135, read in full as the Treasury’s own PDF: the authorising language, the central-bank carve-out, the expiry of 7 April 2027 and the signature block with its time stamp are quoted from the instrument. 2 The Office of Foreign Assets Control’s recent-actions listing for 9 October 2026, which carries both the Court’s designation and the general licence under the same action date. 3 The announcement of the diesel volumes as carried in coverage of 9 October, and the Russian cabinet’s own partial lifting of its export ban effective 10 October, with the deputy prime minister’s month-by-month schedule, reported by the Russian state agency. 4 The motoring association’s own national average fuel-price page, read 10 October 2026, for the current and year-ago diesel averages; the refined-product contract’s daily and weekly moves are from its exchange price series. 5 Remarks at the White House on 10 October and the Ukrainian president’s statements of 9 and 10 October, as reported by a Kyiv newspaper; its own characterisation of having been blindsided is from its separate reporting. 6 The Russian state agency’s reports of the cabinet decision and of the presidents’ telephone call. A European Union quotation carried in the same report reaches this desk only through that agency and is not printed here. 7 Named analysts quoted in agency and wire coverage of 9–10 October 2026. 8 Volume arithmetic from the published tonnages against United States diesel consumption as given in that coverage; the collapse in Russian diesel exports and the third-quarter import are from the same reporting; the former sanctions official is quoted there.

PANAMA • THE ISTHMUS SHOOK

A red alert, ten provinces, and no one killed

The loss model put the central estimate at seventy-one dead. By Saturday night Panama had counted twenty-seven injured and none.

At 17:56 UTC on Friday a magnitude 7.7 earthquake broke twelve kilometres beneath the Azuero peninsula, twelve kilometres west-south-west of Pitaloza Arriba. Shaking reached intensity **IX**; peak ground acceleration **0.772g**. A **6.6** followed two and a half hours later with a tsunami flag set, and a **6.0** before dawn on Saturday.¹

The United States Geological Survey's loss model went **red** — its highest economic alert: **"Extensive damage is probable and the disaster is likely widespread"**, with losses estimated at **1–20 per cent of Panama's GDP** and a central estimate of **US\$3.55 billion**. For deaths it ran **yellow**, central estimate **71**, drawing on a 1991 Costa Rican analogue that killed 75.²

The ground disagreed. Panama declared a state of emergency on Saturday with damage in **all ten provinces** and two Indigenous territories — about **420 homes**, roughly as many schools, seven hotels, at least thirteen churches and nine bridges, and the **Church of San Atanasio**, a national heritage site since 1938, collapsed. More than a hundred aftershocks. Injuries: **27**, minor to moderate. Deaths attributed: **none**. The canal reported operations **"continuing normally"**.³

The model was not wrong about the shaking. It was wrong about what the shaking would find.

A model that estimates seventy-one and finds zero has not failed; it has described a country that has changed since the events the model learned from. The honest caveat is that the count was a day old at press time, and landslides had cut some communities off.³

THE CHATTER • THE NUMBER THE MAGNITUDE KEPT MOVING

The magnitude was published at **8.0**, revised to **7.6**, then settled at **7.7** — routine as more stations report, and the reason early coverage disagreed with itself. One outlet counted **147** aftershocks against civil protection's hundred-plus. Tsunami warnings were issued and lifted within hours; the survey's tsunami flag sat on the **6.6**, not on the main shock. Resident **Tony Jiménez**, whose house partly collapsed, said in ninety years he had known nothing like it.³

THE SCEPTIC • A PRESSURE READING IS A CONTRACT

Yesterday this desk set out Mexico's **\$175m** parametric catastrophe bond and the pressures that govern it: **937 millibars** to attach at all, and **932** as the bar for a quarter payout. Hurricane **Simon** then ran **938mb at noon UTC on Saturday, 933 by six, and 932 at nine** — 150mph, a hundred miles south-south-west of Manzanillo, landfall on west-central Mexico expected **today**. The threshold named on Saturday morning was met on Saturday night. Two cautions: the payout ladder is the insurance trade's reading, not published deal documents, and the pressure must be met inside the right coastal box. In September, Hurricane Polo reached trigger pressure and weakened before landfall, and paid nothing.⁴

71 → 0

MODELLED FATALITIES AGAINST THE OFFICIAL COUNT ON SATURDAY NIGHT²

IN BRIEF

Riyadh — King Khalid airport struck twice in three days. **Three Saudis killed** on Thursday, including an airline captain; on Saturday a hospital source reported dozens hurt, **at least five** in intensive care. Flights diverted or cancelled; four embassies told citizens to avoid the airport.⁵

One more from Friday's prize, for the record: the laureate drew a response from the American president calling the award **"an indelible stain"** on Norway, and claiming **"I know nothing about this woman, and neither does anyone else!"**⁶

SOURCES 1 The United States Geological Survey's own event service for the main shock and the two large aftershocks, read as the agency's machine-readable record: origin times, magnitudes, depths, locations, the intensity and ground-motion maxima, and the tsunami flag. 2 The same agency's loss-estimate product for the event, read at source: the red economic alert and its quoted wording, the one-to-twenty-per-cent range, the central economic and fatality estimates and the 1991 Costa Rican analogue. 3 Agency reporting from Panama of 4 The National Hurricane Center's public advisory of 3pm CST Saturday 5 Reporting of 6 Remarks reported overnight on 9–10 October 2026.

SINGAPORE • THE ADVERTISING LAYER

Parliament went after the listing, not the vehicle

Four Acts rewritten at once, and the new offence is publishing. Importing an illegal device and advertising one now carry the same ceiling.

On Tuesday the **Land Transport and Related Matters (No. 2) Bill** had its second reading, and it does something the previous decade of active-mobility law did not: it makes the **advertisement** the offence. A new section creates an “**offending advertisement**” for a non-compliant device, battery or mobility vehicle, punishable by up to **\$10,000** and **twelve months** for an individual — **\$20,000** and **twenty-four months** on repeat, and **\$20,000** rising to **\$40,000** for a company.¹

The reason is a number. **49** active-mobility device fires in 2025 alone. Around those sit the trade figures: about **72,000** taxi and private-hire drivers; the cross-border taxi quota lifted from **200** to **300** a side in May, with daily trips up about **20 per cent** and Singapore’s side fully used while Malaysia has taken up half; and the window in which the authority may hold a seized vehicle extended from **one month** to **three**, because its investigations run three to four.²

*The device was always findable.
The listing is what the state could not reach.*

And the haze has not cleared. At **5am this morning** the 24-hour index read **Central 155, West 153, East 141**, with north and south at 119 — unhealthy everywhere, but below Friday’s 192. One-hour PM2.5 sat at **93 micrograms** in the centre: Band 2, one band below Friday’s excursion.³

THE CHATTER • “24 HOUR AVERAGE, HOW TO REACH”

The Education Minister said on Saturday that schools could close and national examinations be postponed if the **next day’s 24-hour forecast** entered the hazardous range — **above 300** — announced around **8pm the evening before**. On HardwareZone’s forum the response was near-total disbelief that 300 is reachable. **bigrooster**: “**Don’t think the NEA ‘official’ PSI would reach this figure.**” **lxb_70** joked it “**will stays at 299**”. **KosmoKramer** put the mechanism in six words: “**24 hour average, how to reach.**” **shikoo** supplied the anchor — the 3-hour index hit **401** on **21 June 2013**, on a metric retired in 2016.⁴

THE SCEPTIC • THE TRIGGER SITS ON THE SLOWEST DIAL

They are not wrong about the mechanism. A closure trigger set on a **24-hour average forecast** is attached to the one indicator least able to spike, while the poster the agency itself publishes tells you to use the **1-hour PM2.5** for immediate activity and the 24-hour figure only for tomorrow. A Band 3 hour — **151–250 micrograms**, at which vulnerable people are told to avoid all outdoor activity — can sit comfortably inside a 24-hour reading nowhere near 300.⁵

49

ACTIVE-MOBILITY DEVICE FIRES IN 2025, THE FIGURE THE IMPORT AND ADVERTISING PENALTIES ANSWER²

ALSO THIS WEEK

Health ministry, 8 Oct — a 2026 modelling study using local data indicates rising lung cancer among never-smokers in both sexes, but on haze specifically: “**the effect of our periodic haze exposure will only be known much later once correlational studies are done.**”⁶

The Minister of State left one door open on purpose. There are no penalties for **passengers** of illegal point-to-point services — “**for now**”. Two words doing a lot of work.⁷

SOURCES 1 The Bill itself, read as the Government Gazette Bills Supplement and text-extracted: the new advertising and misrepresentation offences, the battery specification-notice duty and its defined contents, the import penalties, the point-to-point fine increase, the continuing daily penalty, and the five-year definition of a repeat offender are taken from its clauses. The Bill’s passage at the end of the 7 October sitting rests on a single local report; the ministry publishes only the second-reading round-up. 2 The Ministry of Transport’s own published round-up speech of 7 October 2026 for the fires figure, the driver population, the cross-border quota and trip growth, the extension of the vehicle-holding window, and the “for now” remark on passengers. An impounding figure circulating in local reporting could not be reconciled against a second source and is not printed. 3 The environment agency’s real-time pollutant feeds, read at the national data service at 5am on 11 October 2026 for the 24-hour index by region and the 1-hour fine-particulate readings. 4 The Education Minister’s statement of 10 October 2026 as reported locally — the post itself could not be read at source — and a HardwareZone discussion thread of the same evening, quoted directly from the thread. The 2013 record is a forum participant’s recollection of a metric since retired. 5 The environment agency’s own haze health advisory, edition dated June 2026, read as published, for both band tables and for the instruction on which index to use for which purpose; the World Health Organisation’s 24-hour and annual fine-particulate guideline values are taken from its own press material, the guideline document itself being unreachable to this desk. 6 Written parliamentary answers of 8 October 2026, read on the health ministry’s own newsroom. 7 The environment ministry’s media soundbite of 10 October 2026, read at source.

BUY IT ONCE · SOCKS

The good toe costs about a dollar. The rest is brand

Gauge is a needle count, not a quality ladder. And the word the trade uses for the premium finish may mean the cheap one.

Start with the drum. **Gauge** in a sock is the number of latch needles standing around the cylinder of a circular knitting machine — needles on a drum, not stitches per inch of cloth. The cylinder stays roughly constant at **3½ to 4¾ inches**, so more needles means smaller stitches and denser fabric. The bands run **84–108** needles for thick cushioned outdoor socks, **120–144** for everyday crew, **168–176** for fine premium, and **200** for luxury dress hosiery, where each needle is about a fiftieth of an inch across.¹

Here is the part the marketing omits: a 200-needle machine **cannot** knit the thick terry cushioning a hiking sock needs. Fine gauge also demands fine yarn — typically **50 to 100 denier** for dress applications — and runs slower, which is why the trade puts 200-needle production **30 to 40 per cent** above coarser work. There is no better gauge, only a gauge matched to a job — and a maker who names the number is telling you which job it chose.¹

Then the toe, which is the clearest tell and the biggest trap. A toe can be **cut and sewn**, leaving a ridge you feel; or **linked** — re-knitted loop by loop on a linking machine for a flat join. On Styleforum, **max b** punctures the romance: hand linking is still machine work, and the handwork is **hanging loops on hooks**. He adds the fact that should change how you shop — newer machines close the toe *during* knitting, to the same result, and the industry moved that way because of a **shortage of skilled workers in Europe**, not to cut cost. “Seamless” is not a downgrade.²

THE CHATTER · NOBODY IS CONSISTENT, INCLUDING THE MAKERS

Bresciani is the reference for linked toes — but **bengal-stripe** notes its **linen** pair is not linked, because linen is very hard to link by hand, while a secondary source says flatly that all its socks are. **Pantherella** is openly inconsistent: **Dmax** says most have hand-linked toes, and **DocHolliday** corrects him in the next post — “**not all Pantherellas have the hand-linked toe, and I own some that don’t**”. **Mazarin** says it plainly: the toe is “**remeshed stitch by stitch**”. **Corgi’s** site uses neither term, only “**carefully knitted and finished by hand**”. The label is unreliable; the seam is not. Run a thumb across it.²

THE SCEPTIC · THE WORD THAT MAY MEAN THE OPPOSITE

This desk set out to explain that a “**Rosso**” toe is the hand-linked premium finish. The one trade source it could read says the reverse, listing **hand-linked** (dearest, seam undetectable), **machine-linked**, and “**rosso (overlock)**” — closed straight off the knitting, an overlocked ridge, **cheapest and fastest**, the default for most commercial production.³

~\$1

THE REPORTED PRICE STEP BETWEEN AN UNLINKED AND A LINKED TOE IN ONE MAKER’S OWN RANGE²

NEXT ON THE BENCH

Cast-iron kettles & tetsubin — Nambu ironware, and the iron-in-the-water claim tested.

Enamelware & camp mugs — glass fused to steel, and why the rim goes first.

Chef’s whites & work shirts — oxford weight, collar build, single-needle seams.

The buy-once line: pay for the linked toe and the named needle count, not for the word on the label. The word is unreliable; the seam is not.

SOURCES 1 A sock manufacturer’s own technical explainer on needle count, read at source: the definition of gauge as needles around the cylinder, the cylinder diameters, the four named bands and their uses, the per-needle width at 200, the fine-denier yarn requirement, the stated 30-to-40-per-cent production-cost premium, and the statement that a fine-gauge machine cannot produce thick terry cushioning. 2 The Styleforum thread “Best High-Grade, OTC, Hand-Linked Socks Internationally?” of July 2023 and a separate Pantherella thread, both read at source: the cut-and-sewn against linked mechanism, the quoted remarks on hand linking being machine work and on hanging loops, the account of newer machines closing the toe during knitting and the attribution of that shift to a skilled-labour shortage, the observation about linen, the contradicting posts about one maker’s consistency, and the reported price step between unlinked and linked toes in one range. The claim that one maker links all its socks is from a secondary article and is contradicted in that thread. 3 The same manufacturer’s explainer on construction methods, read at source, which defines three toe-closure methods and places the overlocked variant as cheapest and most common; and its statement that there is no reliable in-store hand test for gauge. This desk could not confirm any machine maker of that name; the domain is parked. 4 Knitting references and United States patent literature on plated fabrics, read at source, for the mechanism and for the cotton-face, synthetic-back sock construction quoted. This desk found no source demonstrating a wool-face, cotton-back plated sock and asserts none.

TECHNOLOGY · ARM & QUALCOMM

The jury deliberated four hours, then went home

Wilmington is being asked to price something no chip contains: permission to design one. Deliberations resume Tuesday, two days after this issue prints.

The thing on trial is not a chip. For five days in a Delaware courtroom, Qualcomm and Arm argued over an architecture licence — the document deciding whether a company may build a processor at all — and on Friday afternoon a jury took the question away with it. About **four hours** of deliberation, then the weekend. They return **Tuesday 13 October**.¹

Three counts, before **Judge Maryellen Noreika**, who heard the 2024 round too. That Arm withheld patches and testing tools. That it broke a promise to keep Qualcomm's payments **within ten per cent** of the lowest price it charges anyone for comparable designs. And that it leaked a breach-notice letter to spoil Qualcomm's dealings with Meta — a deal counsel **Karen Dunn** said lost **US\$170 million**. Arm's answer: **"They were not harmed in the least."**¹

The clause nobody has ruled on is what makes it a page. If Arm breached, Qualcomm may be entitled to stop paying royalties **for five years**; Arm says that is unenforceable, and Noreika has not said. A second trial the same week, same judge, no jury, asks whether Arm bargained in good faith over **ARMv10**. Chief executive **Cristiano Amon** testified the rise Arm wants from v9 to v10 is **1,800 per cent**. One outlet carries that and the newswire carries no damages figure at all, so take the scale, not the decimal.²

Two days earlier the rent moved the other way. **Netlist** filed an 8-K recording a settlement with **Micron**: mutual release, a five-year portfolio licence, **"quarterly license fees of \$30 million"** across **twenty quarters**. We printed that schedule in No. 127 as a judgment. It is a licence — and Micron bought **ten**

million Netlist shares for one million dollars. You do not take equity in an adversary.³

THE CHATTER · THE DIRECTION OF TRAVEL REVERSED

On 5 October the wires reported Qualcomm licensing patents from **Huawei** — the payer and the paid changing places. The scope is already contested: Huawei describes a broad agreement across AI, networking and 5G, while Qualcomm is reported saying the folding-logic technology in the headline is **"not part of this deal"**. Both claims are second-hand.⁴

THE SCEPTIC · TWO INCUMBENTS, NOT A THAW

The commenter **AlanYx** reads it the opposite way: not a thaw but a **"patent oligopoly"** that could itself be anticompetitive — two holders of enormous portfolios agreeing not to shoot. He brings numbers rather than mood. Qualcomm earns **over US\$5 billion a year** from licensing, and since China's 2015 antitrust settlement its manufacturers pay royalties on **65 per cent of net selling price** at home.⁵

10%

THE MOST QUALCOMM'S PAYMENTS MAY EXCEED ARM'S LOWEST COMPARABLE PRICE, UNDER THE CLAUSE AT ISSUE¹

STILL ON THE SHELF

TSMC — September **NT\$511,857m**, up 54.6%; the quarter **NT\$1.494tn**, about two per cent above its own guided top. Call **15 October**.⁶

A correction to our own arithmetic. Nos. 127 and 128 said TSMC beat guidance only below **NT\$32.63** to the dollar. The rate TSMC publishes with that guidance is **32.0**, and at 32.0 the quarter clears the top anyway. The conclusion survives; the rate was wrong.⁶

SOURCES 1 The newswire report of 9 October 2026 on the trial's close, read in syndication: court, judge, the three counts, the ten-per-cent clause, the Meta allegation, the US\$170m figure and both counsels' words are from it. It states no damages figure. 2 A single secondary outlet, 9 October 2026, for Mr Amon's 1,800-per-cent testimony and for the antitrust investigation opened into Arm's licensing in May 2026. Single-sourced, and flagged as such in the text. 3 Netlist's Form 8-K filed 6 October 2026 for the event of 5 October, read at the Commission's own archive: Item 1.01 for the settlement, release and five-year portfolio licence, with the quarterly fee and the twenty quarters quoted from it; Item 3.02 for the ten million shares at one million dollars and the unlock schedule. 4 The 5 October report of the Qualcomm-Huawei licence, read via the discussion thread carrying it, the originating newsroom being paywalled to this desk; the "not part of this deal" line is relayed in that thread and is not confirmed at a Qualcomm source. 5 Comments by the user AlanYx on that thread, quoted and summarised; the licensing revenue, the 65-per-cent royalty base and the consortium figure are his, given in-thread. 6 TSMC's own monthly revenue page for September 2026 and the nine-month total, and its second-quarter investor page for third-quarter guidance of US\$44.6–45.8bn at an assumed NT\$32.0 to the US dollar. The quarterly total in New Taiwan dollars, and the comparison against the guided range, are this desk's arithmetic from those two pages. 7 Samsung's preliminary third-quarter announcement of 8 October as carried in coverage; Samsung's own investor pages were unreachable from this desk on every path tried. The divisional loss estimates are securities-house and forum figures, not disclosure, and disagree with each other by an order of magnitude. 8 Mistral's own announcement page for Large 4, read at source, for the parameter counts and the training hardware; the absence of weights and of a named licence is the state of that page on 11 October.

THE HOME LAB • THE EXPERT CACHE

It merged. Then two people made it slower

The host-memory cache for mixture-of-experts models is in master, with a claimed 2.2× decode. On dual cards one tester measured a third slower.

The thread this desk has followed since No. 127 has closed. **PR 29887** — a GPU cache for mixture-of-experts weights parked in system memory — was **merged into master on 7 October**, with **30112**, which extends it across multiple GPUs, landing the same day. It adds a flag, **--moe-cache-mib**: host-resident expert matrices execute on the GPU from a least-recently-used cache, and only misses are uploaded. It applies to batches up to **32 tokens**, and the author suggests sizing the cache at about **ten per cent** of total expert size.¹

The author's own figures are large. On a 4090, decode rises from **25.0 to 39.4 tokens a second**; on a 5090, from **30.8 to 54.5**, and as high as **67.8** with a nineteen-gigabyte cache — a **2.2×**. Those are the author's benchmarks on his own hardware.¹

What independent testers found is messier, and in one case negative. On an AMD R9700 under Windows, decode went from **11.0 to 14.5 tokens a second** at an eight-gigabyte cache and **27.6** at sixteen — and prompt processing, which the earlier version taxed, **did not drop**. But a tester on **dual 3090s**, bypassing the multi-device check locally, measured a single-GPU gain of **one to five per cent** and a dual-GPU result **25 to 34 per cent slower**. A flat regression. A separate user reported the model repeating the word “the” during long generations with the cache on, fixed by moving top-k from 20 to 2048 at some cost in speed — anecdotal, unconfirmed.¹

Two merges this week, and in both the person who reproduced it found a smaller number than the person who wrote it.

The pattern repeated on **10 October** with **PR 29809**, which speeds Intel's path by decoding a four-bit format arithmetically instead of by lookup. The author measured decode on gpt-oss-20b rising **55.8 to 106.6 tokens a second**. An independent tester on a

different Arc card confirmed a **4.9×** kernel-level speedup and about **41 per cent** on token generation — a real gain, and well under double. The reviewer who approved it had found, on a third card, prompt processing still near **a tenth lower** after the author's fix. It merged with that discrepancy unexplained.²

THE CHATTER • HALF THE MEMORY, THE SAME MONEY

NVIDIA announced a **64GB DGX Spark** on 2 October at **US\$4,999**, shipping **23 October** through six OEMs rather than directly. It runs models to **100 billion** parameters; two linked by a single cable pool to **128GB** and about 200 billion. The local-model forum did the comparison immediately and unkindly: this is half the memory of the original at the same price. Put it beside the week's memory numbers and it stops looking like greed and starts looking like arithmetic — phone-grade memory ran **up 175 per cent** year on year in the second quarter, with a further **20 per cent** expected in the third, which is why one handset maker has asked partners to cut fourth-quarter supply by **20 to 30 per cent**. An industry source puts it plainly: those phones “**currently yield no profit at all when sold**”.³

THE SCEPTIC • BEATEN IN GERMAN BY A SMALLER CHINESE MODEL

The week's sovereignty release was **Kolibri-1: 78 billion** parameters with **3.46 billion** active, Apache-licensed weights, FP8, a million-token context, German and English only, about **78GB** on disk. Then the commenter **amoshebb** ran the obvious check: “**Qwen3.8 27B beats Kolibri 79.9 vs 70.8 in German in Kolibri's harness on Kolibri's benchmark**.” A 78-billion sovereign German model, beaten in German by a 27-billion Chinese one, on its own evaluation. Others noted the comparison set omits the newer rival and benchmarks against a model a year older. A member of the training team answered in the thread that the competing models “**have solid performance on benchmarks**”, that the report is transparent about it, and that sovereignty is “**mostly about choice and control over your data**”. That exchange is the honest state of the argument. Note too that the licence covers the weights and configuration files only — not the code, architecture or training method.⁴

WORTH THE EVENING

SOURCES 1 The pull request itself on the project's repository, read at source: the merge date and commit, the flag and caching mechanism, the batch limit and sizing suggestion, the author's benchmark figures on both cards, and the in-thread reports from independent testers including the AMD result, the dual-card regression and the repeated-token anecdote. The companion multi-GPU pull request merged the same day. 2 October 2026 for the memory, price, ship date, OEM-only distribution, model-size limits and cable pooling; the community reaction is from the local-model forum of 5 and 3 NVIDIA's own blog announcement of 4 The model's own card for the parameter counts, licence scope, numeric format, context, languages and footprint; and the discussion thread for the quoted comparison, the observations on the comparison set, and the training-team member's reply, all quoted as posted. A figure for tokens per second circulating in secondary blogs could not be located in that thread and is not printed. 5 The Home Assistant release post of

THE KIT · GARMIN'S ENDURO 4

Garmin sent no review units. That is the review

A new strap, a faster chip and thirty-two more gigabytes, at a hundred dollars over the street price of the watch it replaces. Singapore has a listing but no price.

The **Enduro 4** was announced on **6 October** and went on sale in America on the 9th: **51mm**, titanium bezel, sapphire, a 1.4-inch **280×280** transfective screen, solar, **10 ATM**, a claimed **36 days** rising to **90 with sun**, and **120 hours** of GPS. **US\$899.99**. Every one of those battery figures is Garmin's own; nobody independent has published a measured result.¹

Garmin's own Singapore page contradicts itself before anyone else gets a chance to. The specification table says **32GB** of storage; the music section on the same page says **64GB**. The weight is given as **63 grams** while the one reviewer who has handled all three says the new strap takes it to **66**. And the page carries a **"BUY NOW"** button over the words **"Coming Soon"**, with **no Singapore dollar price anywhere** — not on the page, not on any of its four store links.¹

What is genuinely new, per the only independent voice: the base **Fenix 9** processor, **fifty per cent more RAM**, doubled storage, a grey bezel and a **ComfortFit** strap he calls **"far better"**. Unchanged: the panel, the solar cells, the case and **every battery claim**. Opening a 50km course takes **about eight seconds on all three** watches. Creating a 23km route: **Enduro 3, one minute fifteen; Enduro 4, forty-five seconds; Fenix 9 Pro, twenty-eight**.²

Almost every headline feature reaches the Enduro 3 and Fenix 8 by update. Four things are hardware-gated: perspective map view, faster zoom and heading, an archery mode, and dynamic battery GPS.²

THE CHATTER · R/GARMIN IS NOT HAVING IT

The owner thread opened by **u/chipmux** on the 6th set the tone: **"Checking the comparison page i hardly see any difference..."** **u/Own-Produce-3363** went further — **"the band is legit the only thing that's clearly different when you hold them side by side... the software stuff will hit the e3 in a month anyway"**. **u/brightvalve**, drily: **"I can see a pretty big difference: \$100."** And the detail that earns its own sentence, from **u/Clear-Coyote-1764**: **"It is just strange that neither Des and DCR are doing a review."** **u/Mother_Fennel9825** supplied the explanation: **"Seems that Garmin didn't send the devices for review."**³

THE SCEPTIC · BUY THE WATCH IT REPLACES

The reviewer's own verdict is that the speed gains are **"mostly 'shrug'"**, and that the watch is aimed at owners of the first and second Enduro, **not** the third. For a reader who buys once and is done, the sum is unkind: against an Enduro 3 selling at **\$799**, the hundred dollars buys thirty-two gigabytes, thirty seconds off a route calculation, a map view and a better strap — with no independent battery test published and no Singapore price at all. The quality entry point here may genuinely be the outgoing model. What would change it: a measured battery result that beats the Enduro 3, or a Singapore price that undercuts the import.²

1:15 → 0:45

CREATING A 23KM ROUTE ON THE WRIST; THE WATCH ABOVE IT DOES IT IN 28 SECONDS²

COROS Pace 4 Pro, US\$449 — and the one product this week with a full instrumented review. COROS claims **60 hours** of maximum GPS; the reviewer **"consistently got under 20"**, tracing it to a bug that re-scans for sensors at every stop, with a fix promised in November. On one ninety-minute run the app reported **2.6 per cent** of battery used while his photographs showed **69 down to 61**. He calls the chart **"hilariously wrong"** for sport.⁴

SOURCES 1 Garmin's own Singapore product page for the Enduro 4, read at source on 11 October 2026: the case, display, water-resistance and sensor specification, the claimed battery figures, the internally inconsistent storage figures, the stated weight, the "Coming Soon" status and the absence of any Singapore dollar price on the page or on its four store links. The dollar price and the announcement and on-sale dates are as published in launch coverage; Garmin's United States product paths and its newsroom were unreachable from this desk. 2 DC Rainmaker's comparison review of 9 October 2026, read at source: the processor, memory and storage changes, the strap verdict quoted, the list of unchanged components, the measured course-opening and route-creation timings across the three watches, the division between software features trickling down and the four hardware-gated ones, the quoted verdict and the statement that the watch targets earlier Enduro owners. The reviewer states he has only begun battery testing and has published no measured battery result. 3 An owner thread on the Garmin subreddit opened 6 October 2026, read through its syndication feed; the comments are quoted verbatim with their usernames. The suggestion that review units were not seeded is a forum participant's inference, presented here as such. 4 The same reviewer's instrumented review of the COROS Pace 4 Pro, 8 October 2026, read at source for the price, the manufacturer's battery claim, his measured result, the sensor-rescan explanation, the promised November fix and the battery-chart discrepancy with his own photographs. 5 Launch coverage of 8 October 2026 for the lens price, ship date, mounts, licensing arrangement and weight; the maker's own newsroom is script-rendered and returned no article to this desk, so the optical claims remain unverified by any independent measurement.

THE GOOD LIFE · BREMONT'S DEEP BLUE

The limit exists. The premium for it does not

Two hundred and fifty pieces, says the product page. The collection grid beside it prints no limit at all — and charges the same for an unlimited sibling.

No. 128 left a question open: Bremont's **Supermarine Full Ceramic Deep Blue** was reported at 250 pieces by three magazines while the maker printed nothing. It is now answered, and the answer is odder than either. Bremont's own product page states **"Limited edition: 250 pieces worldwide"**. Its own Supermarine collection grid, one click away, prints piece counts for the Polar White (150) and others — and **no limit at all** against the three Deep Blue references.¹

The watch is serious. A mono-block **blue ceramic** case over a titanium inner case, **43mm by 13mm, 74 grams** of head, **500 metres** with a helium valve, a three-dimensional wave dial, and the **BB64AH** — a Bremont-signed **Sellita SW300-1** at 4Hz with a **56-hour** reserve. Price, as published: **£6,450** on Bremont's own site, **US\$7,400 before taxes, €7,750**. The spread is tax, not arbitrage.¹

Now put the limit beside the price list. On Bremont's own grid the 250-piece Deep Blue is **£6,450** — identical to the **150-piece** Polar White, and **£500 more** than the Tactical Black at £5,950, which carries no stated limit whatever. Scarcity that costs nothing extra is not scarcity; it is a production run with a number attached.¹

Scarcity that commands no premium is a production run with a number attached.

The Singapore reality is plainer still. Bremont lists **one boutique in Asia** — Lyndhurst Terrace, Hong Kong. Singapore exists in the storefront selector as **"Singapore / GBP"**: you buy direct, in sterling, free delivery above £2,000, seven to ten working days. The same page carries a banner saying the watch

"ships early January 2025" next to an **"In Stock"** label.¹

THE CHATTER · THE HATERS WILL BE HERE SHORTLY

Monochrome's comment thread did what comment threads do, and quickly. Ed, 8 October: **"Sharp looking watch. The haters will be here shortly."** JMM, the same day: **"That case sure does not look put together well..."** RG, the next morning: **"V good looking diver, esp on the nato. Now bring it in Titanium please."** That is the whole argument in three lines, and the third is the useful one — the people who like it want it lighter.²

THE SCEPTIC · THE WORD AT SIX O'CLOCK

Brandon Moore of SJX raises the thing nobody else will. The dial says **"London"** at six o'clock, which he calls misleading given where the watch is actually made, likening it to a Danish-signed watch built in Biel. He calls the point **"conceptually annoying"** rather than disqualifying — then lands the specification blows: the Sellita-based calibre is **"somewhat outgunned"** by the chronometer-certified movement in its obvious rival, and its **56-hour** reserve falls short of the **68 hours** Bremont itself fits in another line.³

£6,450

THE 250-PIECE DEEP BLUE — THE SAME MONEY AS A 150-PIECE SIBLING¹

ALSO ON THE BENCH

Seiko's panda — a 2024 concept reaches production as the **HHK001/HHK002**: 43mm steel quartz chronograph, pushers shaped as panda ears, and a **"sasameter"** flange reading speed to **30km/h. 3,000** and **2,000** pieces, **US\$540**, from November. The Japan-trip object of the issue.⁴

For a reader who buys once and is done, the honest line is that the limit is real and the premium is not. Wait for titanium, or buy the Tactical Black and keep the £500.

SOURCES 1 Bremont's own product page for the Supermarine Full Ceramic Deep Blue, read at source on 11 October 2026: the limitation statement, the case, movement and water-resistance specification, the three strap references, the sterling price, the delivery terms and the stale shipping banner. The absence of any stated limit against the Deep Blue entries, and the prices of the Polar White and Tactical Black, are from Bremont's own Supermarine collection grid. The dollar and euro prices are as published by two watch magazines the same week; the observation that the spread is tax rests on the dollar figure being stated as excluding taxes. 2 Reader comments on Monochrome Watches' article of 8 October 2026, quoted verbatim with their usernames and dates as published on that page. 3 Brandon Moore's review for SJX Watches, 8 October 2026, read at source; the movement comparison, the power-reserve comparison with Bremont's own other line, the remark on the dial signature and the observations on the helium valve and on ceramic are his. 4 SJX Watches, 7, 8 and 9 October 2026, for the Seiko production models and their specification, limits and dollar price; for the Ebel transaction, which that report does not support with a linked release or a quoted party and which is flagged here as unconfirmed; and for the online sale's opening and closing times and lot estimates. 5 iFi's own product page for the headphone amplifier, read at source for the sterling price, the power and distortion figures, the sold-out status and the internal contradiction between its marketing copy and its specification table. No independent measurement of this revision could be found; the enthusiast forums that would carry one were unreachable to this desk.

SCREEN & SOUND · OTHER MOMMY

Eighteen per cent, and twelve million on Friday

Universal did not screen it for American critics. Fifty-six reviews landed in a day once the embargo lifted, and the audience had already bought the ticket.

On Thursday **Other Mommy** had **two** logged reviews, both unfavourable, both from outside the United States, because Universal had not screened it for American press. By Saturday it had **fifty-six**, and a Rotten Tomatoes score of **18 per cent**. Metacritic, working from a thinner board of **eleven**, has it at **39**. The audience numbers run warmer and not warm: **46 per cent** from verified ratings, a **4.1** user score.¹

None of which reached the box office in time. The film took **US\$12.6 million on Friday alone** from **3,365** theatres — against a full-weekend forecast of **\$17m to \$22m**. One day covered most of three. The comparison is the prior week's opener, which managed **\$32.0 million** across a whole weekend and now stands at a **\$46.4m** cume.²

A caution on the figures, because the board is mid-update: the weekend has not closed, Friday's numbers are part estimate, and the title page shows a domestic total identical to its Friday gross with no theatre count or budget. Treat every cume on this page as provisional.²

The critics' complaint and the audience's best joke are the same complaint, at different lengths.

And the continuity thread has settled rather than collapsed. **The Social Reckoning** ran **61 per cent** from **120** reviews in No. 127 and **56** from **179** in No. 128; it now sits at **55 per cent** from **197**, with Metacritic at **52** from **55**. One point lost across eighteen more reviews is a verdict, not a slide.¹

THE CHATTER · "I ORDERED CORALINE ON TEMU"

Letterboxd did the review in seven words. **shai**, one star: **"i ordered coraline on temu and this is what i got"**. **Pierre Locher**, one and a half: **"CGI galore."** **kez**, three stars and the sharpest of them: **"the surprise drop of the first trailer was way scarier and better than the actual movie"**. **Nikiee!**: **"this felt like if Smile and Coraline had a baby"**. Set that against **Alonso Duralde** in *The Film Verdict*, complaining the film **"has filched so many of its good ideas from elsewhere"**, and the professional and the amateur have written the same sentence.³

THE SCEPTIC · READ THE SPREAD, NOT THE AVERAGE

An aggregate of 39 hides a board that runs from **68** to **12**. **Nick Schager** in *The Daily Beast* praises its **"unbridled rollercoaster momentum and hallucinatory haunted-house energy"**; **Charles Lyons-Burt** in *Slant* calls it **"a run-on sentence with no periods or semicolons"**; **Carlos Morales** at *IGN* says it **"never figures out its own identity"**; and **Johnny Oleksinski** of the *New York Post*, at **12**, promises **"you will feel noticeably dumber after you leave"**. A fifty-six-point range across ten critics is not a consensus; it is a film people disagree about violently, compressed into one number. One lower score is listed in a summary and absent from the board — this desk does not quote it.⁴

ON THE RECORD PLAYER

Pet Shop Boys with Andrew Hodges, *A Man From The Future* (9 October, Parlophone) — eight tracks on the life and death of **Alan Turing**, narrated by **Juliet Stevenson** from Hodges' biography, strings by **Sven Helbig** with the Manchester Camerata Octet, closing on the **2009** government apology for Turing's conviction. Composed 2012–13, premiered at the Proms in 2014; this is its first studio release. No chart position yet and no major review this desk could read.⁵

SOURCES 1 Rotten Tomatoes and Metacritic film pages, read at source on 10–11 October 2026, for the critic percentages and counts, the audience percentages and user scores, and the consensus wording. The state of the review count before the embargo lifted, and the absence of American press screenings, are from trade reporting of 8 October 2026. The two earlier figures for the continuity title are this magazine's own, from Nos. 127 and 128. 2 Box Office Mojo's daily chart for Friday 9 October 2026 and its closed weekend chart for 2–4 October, both read at source; the weekend forecast is from a trade preview. The daily page is stamped as partly estimated and the title page had not been updated past Friday, which is stated in the text. 3 User reviews on the film's Letterboxd page, quoted verbatim with their usernames and star ratings as displayed; the page showed no average rating or ratings count when read. The critic quotation is from that critic's published review as excerpted on the aggregator. 4 Metacritic's critic-reviews board for the film, read at source: the scores and excerpts quoted are as published there. One lower-scoring review appears on the summary page but not on the board, and is not quoted. 5 Official Charts' own albums chart for the week of 9–15 October 2026 and its new-releases listing of 9 October, read at source. That page publishes positions and weeks only, not units.

THE FAMILY DESK • CHRONOTYPE AT TWELVE

The late bedtime does nothing at eleven

A causal-inference study of 7,489 children finds no effect a year earlier, and at twelve to thirteen the one thing parents fear most is the one thing it does not find.

A paper published online on **8 October** in the *Journal of Child Psychology and Psychiatry* asks whether a late body clock actually causes adolescent mental-health symptoms, and answers it with an explicit causal design rather than a correlation — marginal structural models with machine-learned weights, run across the **Adolescent Brain Cognitive Development** study — **7,489** children followed from ages nine and ten to thirteen and fourteen.¹

The result splits by age, and the split is the finding. Chronotype measured at **eleven to twelve** produced **no effect on any outcome**. Measured at **twelve to thirteen** — the band a Secondary 1 pupil is in now — a later clock predicted more **externalising** behaviour (**b = 0.29, p = .04**) and more odd perceptual experiences (**b = 0.05, p = .02**). And **no effect on internalising at all**: a null that held, in the authors' own follow-up tests, for anxiety and depression separately and in both sexes.¹

Read that twice, because it inverts the usual worry. The common parental fear is that the late bedtime is making a child of twelve anxious or low. That is the one thing this paper did not find. What it found instead was behaviour and perception, and it found them only in the later window. The authors put it carefully: effects are **“dependent on the dimension of mental health and period of adolescence”**, and the familiar link to low mood **“may not manifest until later adolescence”**.¹

Now the limitations, because they are large. The abstract publishes coefficients and p-values but **no confidence intervals**, and the full text was closed to this desk, so none are printed here. The cohort of 7,489 becomes an analytic sample of about **2,668** — roughly **64 per cent of the children are absent** from the outcome models, and the weighting is carrying that. The p-values are **.04** and **.02** across several

outcomes. And the causal claim rests on an assumption of no unmeasured confounding inside the model, which is a modelling statement, not an experiment.¹

THE CHATTER • FORTY THOUSAND CHILDREN, ONE CONSISTENT FACTOR

A population survey published on **24 September** put the same age band under a much bigger lens: **40,748** Swedish children aged **11, 13 and 15**. Difficulty falling asleep more than once a week travelled with problematic social-media use, cyberbullying, lower well-being and a tighter family budget at every age. The strongest factor was low mental well-being — roughly **threefold** higher odds at eleven and **fourfold** at thirteen and fifteen — with cyberbullying exposure about **twofold** throughout. It is cross-sectional, so the direction is unknowable: poor sleep causing low mood fits the data exactly as well as the reverse. The abstract prints no exact odds ratios and no intervals.²

THE SCEPTIC • “NO, SMALL AND MIXED ASSOCIATIONS”

Professor Candice Odgers of the University of California, Irvine has made the discipline's most careful case against alarm, in *Nature*: the field's efforts, she writes, **“have produced a mix of no, small and mixed associations”**, **“most data are correlative”**, and **“there are, unfortunately, no simple answers”**. Her objection is evidential, not political — she supports platform reform — and her worry is that the focus crowds out known causes: hardship, violence, poor access to services. Put her beside the numbers on this page. No. 127 printed a 12,874-child study in which 26 minutes a day of screen time moved an outcome by **0.04 of a standard deviation**. This issue's lead reports **b = 0.05**. Three independent datasets, three real effects, every one of them small enough that the size is the result.³

This is education rather than a clinical opinion. The usable line for a parent this term is narrow and worth having: the window the data implicates is **now**, not last year, and what it implicates is behaviour, not mood.

SOURCES 1 Visontay and colleagues, “Does later chronotype cause poorer adolescent mental health? An adolescent brain cognitive development study”, *Journal of Child Psychology and Psychiatry*, published online 8 October 2026, read as the abstract record at the National Library of Medicine; the publisher's full text was closed to this desk. Design, cohort, exposure ages and instrument, outcome measures, analytic sample sizes, coefficients and p-values, the post-hoc nulls and the quoted conclusion are all from that record. No confidence intervals are published in it, and none are printed here. 2 Ellertsson and colleagues, “Difficulties falling asleep and psychosocial factors among Swedish adolescents aged 11–15 years: a population-based study”, *Scandinavian Journal of Public Health*, 24 September 2026, read as its abstract record: the sample size, ages, design and the approximate odds described in the authors' own words. That abstract gives no exact odds ratios or intervals. 3 Candice L. Odgers, review of *The Anxious Generation*, *Nature* volume 628, published 29 March 2024, read at source; the three quotations are verbatim. The 0.04 standard-deviation figure is this magazine's own, printed in No. 127 from a 12,874-child study; that article cites no effect sizes of its own and none are attributed to it.

THE TWEEN YEARS · CAFFEINE LABELLING

Asked to publish a limit, the ministry declined

Two MPs asked for milligrams per serving and a front-of-pack warning. The answer says there is no recognised guidance, no international standard, and no data held.

Two members put the same question from different angles. **Mr Alex Yeo** of Potong Pasir asked whether the Health Ministry holds data on children seeking medical attention for caffeine, whether it will study and publish the effects with recommended guidelines, and whether high-caffeine energy drinks should carry warnings. **Mr Melvin Yong** of Radin Mas asked for caffeine in **milligrams per serving** above a threshold, and a standardised front-of-pack advisory for children and adolescents. They were answered together on **8 October**.¹

The answer is a careful set of absences. The ministry **holds no data** on children or youths seeking medical attention for caffeine. It **has never studied** caffeine's effects on children here. There is **no recognised health-based guidance** for caffeine intake and **no international standard** for a safe added-caffeine level. What exists is local paediatric advice, which stands unchanged: **children under 12 should avoid caffeine; those aged 12 to 18 no more than 100mg a day**, roughly a single cup of coffee.¹

It is not a refusal to act so much as a refusal to pretend. Such drinks have sat **below one per cent** of sweetened-beverage sales since 2017, and schools do not stock them: they fail the Healthier Choice test. The ministry **“does not rule out implementing additional measures”**. What it does not answer is the actual question asked: whether milligram labelling or a front-of-pack warning will be required.¹

A guideline nobody has derived cannot be printed on a can.

This advances a thread No. 127 opened, and the advance is in the honesty rather than the policy. That issue noted the age-12 line sitting there with no data either side of it. We now know why there is no data:

nobody has collected it, and the ministry says so in writing rather than producing a number to fill the space. A reader deciding whether their Secondary 1 child may have a bubble tea gets the same answer as before — but can now see what it rests on.¹

THE CHATTER · THE OTHER ANSWER, THE SAME WEEK

The same sitting produced a second written reply worth reading beside it, to **Mr Cai Yinzhou** of Bishan-Toa Payoh, on haze and lung cancer. The ministry says a **2026 modelling study using local data** indicates rising lung-cancer incidence among never-smokers in both sexes, and that fine particulates are linked to lung cancer internationally **“often after long term exposure”**. Then the line that matters for a household reading an air-quality app this week: **“the effect of our periodic haze exposure will only be known much later once correlational studies are done.”** Two questions, one week, the same posture — the state declining to supply certainty it does not have.²

THE SCEPTIC · ABSENCE OF DATA IS NOT A FINDING

The sceptical reading cuts both ways and should. “We hold no data” is an honest answer and a convenient one: it forecloses the question without resolving it, and a ministry that has not studied something cannot be contradicted by its own evidence. The **100mg** adolescent figure is paediatric advice, not a regulated limit, and it is roughly what a single large bubble tea or a tall coffee can carry — so a child of twelve can reach the daily ceiling in one order without any product on the shelf being mislabelled. The parent's practical position is unchanged by the reply: in the absence of a limit, count drinks rather than milligrams. General guidance, not medical advice.¹

100mg

DAILY ADOLESCENT CEILING IN LOCAL PAEDIATRIC ADVICE
— ROUGHLY A SINGLE CUP OF COFFEE¹

SOURCES 1 The Health Ministry's written parliamentary reply on caffeine, dated 8 October 2026 and read on the ministry's own newsroom: the two members and their questions as recorded, the statements that no data is collected and no study conducted, the absence of recognised health-based guidance and of an international standard, the paediatric advice for under-12s and for 12- to 18-year-olds, the sales share of high-caffeine energy drinks since 2017 and their exclusion from schools, and the quoted sentence on additional measures. The observation that the reply does not answer the labelling question is this desk's, from the text of the reply. 2 The ministry's written reply of the same date on lung-cancer trends among never-smokers and haze exposure, read on the same newsroom; the quoted sentences are verbatim. One part of that reply did not render in the text available to this desk and is not summarised here. 3 The Education Minister's statement of 10 October 2026 as reported locally, the post itself being unreadable at source from here; and a Ministry of Education school calendar read at source for the end of Term 4 and the year-end holiday dates.

THE MACRO DESK • A DIESEL SHOCK

Gold rose with the dollar. Bitcoin did not

One force ran the week, and it was refined product, not crude. Central banks cannot ease against a supply shock, so the hedges sorted themselves.

Name the force and the week explains itself. It is not oil in the abstract — it is **diesel**. Crude sat quiet: Brent closed **\$104.72**, WTI **\$91.85**. The pump did not. American retail diesel is **\$6.2824** a gallon, **up 71 per cent** in a year, and the refined contract rose **5.27 per cent** on the week even after Friday's sanctions licence knocked three per cent off it in a day.¹

A central bank cannot ease against that. The Federal Reserve's September minutes, out on Wednesday, name the mechanism in its own words: geopolitics "pushed up prices for crude oil and refined fuel products", and "most participants assessed that another increase would likely be appropriate by year end" — with payrolls at **+29,000**. Staff do not see two per cent until **2029**. The rate is **3¼–4 per cent**.²

Equity split along that fault. Global cap-weighted equity shrugged — **VWRA +0.39 per cent**, the S&P 500 **+1.15** — the index being dominated by companies long the capital-expenditure cycle. What broke was bank-heavy: the **Straits Times Index fell 4.13 per cent** to **5,401.89**, **6.9 per cent** below its 4 September record. Thursday alone took **195.48 points**.⁴

THE LEVELS • FRIDAY 9 OCTOBER CLOSE

VWRA	\$193.50	▲ 0.39%
Global agg (AGGU)	\$5.731	▲ 0.10%
US 10-year	5.24%	▼ 4bp
DXV	102.21	▲ 0.27%
USD/SGD	1.2804	flat
Brent, ICE front	\$104.72	▲ 2.42%
Gold, COMEX	\$4,216.30	▲ 1.30%
Bitcoin	\$82,546	▼ 2.31%
Straits Times	5,401.89	▼ 4.13%

Friday to Friday; 10 October was a Saturday. Treasury yields are the Treasury's own par series; the rest are one provider's exchange

feeds. Not advice.³

THE CHATTER • WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE FOUR

Gold is the cleanest read: **+1.30 per cent** to **\$4,216.30**, rising with a bid dollar and with a 5.24 per cent nominal ten-year. That is not a rates asset behaving; that is a war-and-sanctions asset. **Bitcoin** went the other way, **-2.31 per cent** to **\$82,546**, trading as the long-duration risk asset it is rather than as digital gold. **Global equity** is carried by a handful of very large companies. **Global bonds** are the problem leg: an inflation shock makes the forty a beta, not a brake.⁵

THE SCEPTIC • A TWENTY-ONE-DOLLAR GAP IN ONE PRICE

The Energy Information Administration's physical Dated Brent assessment printed **\$125.44** on 6 October while ICE front-month futures ran **\$100–105** all week — a premium of cargo over paper of **\$21 or more**. A second series reproduces the high prints exactly, so these are not two witnesses but one. Either Atlantic light sweet carries an extraordinary scarcity premium, or one series is mis-stated. This desk prints both and averages neither.⁶

+0.37

EQUITY–BOND CORRELATION OVER NINE SESSIONS TO 9 OCTOBER — THE FORTY IS A BETA, NOT A BRAKE⁵

The regime, named: **a stagflationary fuel shock met by a hiking central bank**. Which puts Wednesday in sharp relief. **MAS publishes its Monetary Policy Statement on 14 October**, confirmed on its own calendar, alongside the Macroeconomic Review — and a third tightening of the year is widely expected after April's and July's. Yet the Singapore dollar sits at **1.2804**, a touch weaker on the month. Tightening the band against a global dollar bid is tightening uphill, and that is the question to put on Wednesday. None of this is advice, and a forecast is a forecast.⁷

SOURCES 1 Exchange price series for the Brent and WTI front months and for the refined-product contract, read for the Friday 9 October close and the week; the retail diesel average and its year-ago comparison are from the motoring association's own national page, read 10 October 2026. 2 The Federal Open Market Committee's minutes of the 15–16 September meeting, published 7 October 2026 and read at the Board's own site, for the quoted passages, the staff inflation projection and the participants' assessment; the September employment report for payrolls and unemployment; and the Committee's own statement of 16 September for the policy decision. 3 The United States Treasury's own daily par yield curve for October 2026, read as published data, for the two-, ten- and thirty-year closes and the curve shape. Levels for the two exchange-traded funds, the dollar index, the currency crosses, the commodity contracts and the Singapore index are one provider's exchange feeds; that single-provider dependence is flagged here, and its ten-year print cross-checks against the Treasury's own series. The bond fund's last print preceded the official close. 4 The same provider's series for the Singapore index and the American index, with the record close of 4 September 2026 as the comparison. 5 This desk's own calculation of the Pearson correlation of nine daily return pairs for the two funds, 29 September to 9 October 2026, from closing prices read at source; the gold and bitcoin moves are from the series above. 6 The Energy Information Administration's own Dated Brent series against the ICE front-month futures, both read at source; the named strategist is quoted from regional market coverage of 8–9 October, and the two brokers' price targets are reported in secondary coverage, so the spread is given without naming the targets. 7 The Monetary Authority of Singapore's own advance release calendar, read at source, for the 14 October 2026 statement and the simultaneous review. The expectation of a third tightening, and the policy-band path behind it, are secondary and attributed as such; the currency level is from the series above.

DOWN THE RABBIT HOLE · DISTANCE SKATING

No tricks, no park. The unit of achievement is a distance

A forty-four-year-old came back to skateboarding this month to cruise without breaking anything. He posted five more times in nine days.

It begins, almost always, with a sentence like this one, posted on **30 September**: **“Hi, I am 44 yo and after a long pause in skateboarding I started longboarding mostly because I just want to cruise and not break my bones in the process.”** Over the next nine days the same rider posted about stability, then wheels, then exercises for the soles of his feet, then which of two boards to buy. The whole arc of falling in, compressed, in public.¹

What he has fallen into is not skateboarding as most people picture it. There are no tricks, no stairs, no park. The board is **33 to 40 inches** rather than eight wide; the wheels are **70 to 105mm** of soft urethane rather than 52mm of hard. You stand on it and push, like a scooter without the handle, and the sport-specific name is **LDP** — long-distance pushing and pumping. The entire gear world exists to make the push cheap in energy: a platform low enough that your leg barely lifts, wheels big enough to roll over grit instead of stopping on it.²

The gateway is a number, and the numbers posted this week are modest and delighted: **“Baby’s first 10 mile ride”** on 10 October; **“3 months and 400 miles later”** at the end of September. And the other half of the hook is the humility. From the same week: **“Suddenly I was on the floor... just immediately hit the ground on my side like a sack of potatoes. That was quite humbling, I felt like I could roll over everything... but today one pebble said ‘not today.’”**¹

Is it genuinely a hobby for someone in their forties? The brand names answer it. The flagship long-distance wheel is the **Dad Bod**, at **US\$150**; its stablemates are the **Love Handles** at \$61 and the **Beefcake** at \$72, and you can buy the Dad Bod T-shirt. Nobody in the threads treats a forty-four-year-old beginner as notable.³

How big is the world? Smaller than the industry reports suggest, and nobody measures it honestly. One research publisher puts the **global skateboard market at US\$3.7bn in 2025**; another puts the same market at **US\$1.56bn**. Neither publishes a longboard figure at all. The real evidence of the scene’s size is better and sadder: a Bristol shop reported in September that a particular 102mm wheel was out of stock across **the whole of Europe**, and that before it rebuilt its own completes there were none of that maker’s complete boards available anywhere in the United Kingdom.⁴

THE CHATTER · TWENTY-FOUR HOURS, AND A RECORD NOBODY CAN AGREE ON

The sport’s marquee format is the **Ultraskate**: twenty-four hours on a measured loop, ride as far as you can. The first was run in Seattle in **May 2007**. The men’s progression runs from **208 miles** in 2008 to **313.17** at the Dutch event in 2017 and **316.82** at Miami in 2025; the women’s from **102** to **262.28** in 2017, with **264.4** listed for 2024. This year’s Miami saw **315.36 miles** — one lap short. And there is a live argument about the headline figure itself: the sport’s archive site has been publicly auditing the governing body since **17 August 2026**, arguing the 2025 record should be **316.82** miles on a 1.46-mile lap rather than the **320.3** published on a 1.476-mile one, citing GPS logs running two to three miles short of official totals.⁵

What the next two pages descend into: where this community actually gathers now that its great forum is offline; what the gear costs and which of it is marketing; what the hobby really costs at each level of seriousness; and whether, in a city with 150 kilometres of park connectors and a legal regime built around motors, any of it is available to a reader here.

SOURCES 1 Posts on the distance-skating and general longboarding subreddits, dated 29 September to 10 October 2026, read at source through the listing endpoint that serves post bodies; the quotations are the authors’ own words, verbatim, from those post bodies. Comment text and subscriber counts were not readable and none are printed. 2 Dimensions, wheel sizes and the definition of the discipline are from the community and maker material cited across this desk, in particular a Singapore retailer’s own explanatory comparison of push heights. 3 Orangatang’s own product pages for the three wheels named and their prices, read at source. 4 Two market-research publishers’ free summaries of paid reports, read at source, giving materially different figures for the same year and neither giving a longboard segment; and a British longboard shop’s own trading notes of 25 September 2026 and 18 July 2025 on European stock availability and tariffs. 5 The sport’s long-running archive and records site, read at source, for the event format and first edition, the men’s and women’s record progressions, this year’s Miami result, and its own dated audit of the governing body’s published record, including the lap-length discrepancy and the GPS-log claim. The audit is that site’s contention, not a settled finding. 6 The organiser’s own page for the New York street race of 17 October 2026, read at source; the quoted lines are its own, as is its statement that a 2012 court injunction declared the race unlawful.

The community map begins with an absence. **Silverfish Longboarding**, the sport's great forum, is not an archive you can browse: it returns a server error on every attempt. The surviving conscience is **Pavedwave**, running since 2004 and still being updated in late September 2026, which describes the diaspora in its own words: **"The whole LDP scene has moved to Facebook, Instagram, Reddit, and various Discords since."** Its blog has **twenty-nine subscribers**.¹

On Reddit the mass room is **r/longboarding** — busy, twenty-plus posts in three days, dominated by downhill, dancing and gear show-off, with this week's best-scoring thread asking whether rotating your wheels is optional. The actual distance room is **r/longboardingDISTANCE**: alive, warm, and tiny — about twenty posts a fortnight, scores of two to thirty-six, and an answer rate that shames bigger rooms, with a five-point gear question drawing forty-two replies. **r/PushCulture**, the name outsiders still cite, serves no posts at all.²

Now the gear, where this sport inverts almost everything cycling taught you. **The deck is the cheap part**. Teach the mechanism first: *drop-through* means the truck baseplate passes through a cutout so the platform sits below the axles; *drop deck* means the standing platform is milled lower than the mounting points; *double drop* is both, and every serious commuter board is one, because a lower deck means less leg travel on every push and less fatigue over twenty kilometres. A Pantheon Pranayama sits about **5.5cm** off the ground against roughly **9cm** for a trick skateboard.³

The deck is the cheap part. There is no frame, and the trucks cost more.

Pantheon's own prices run from **US\$140** for a bamboo cruiser to **\$170** for the Trip and the Pranayama, **\$210** for the pumping flagship and **\$220** for the fendered all-weather board. A complete Trip, built on Paris trucks with its own 92mm wheels, is **US\$358**. Loaded sits a tier up: a rebuilt Tan Tien deck at **\$207** and complete at **\$338**, the Icarus at **\$219** and **\$364**, the bracket-based Fathom complete at **\$389**.

Bustin — which files its distance boards under the product type **"Push"** — starts at **\$109** for a deck.⁴

Learn to read a flex rating, because this is the most common sizing error. Loaded publishes flex as a **rider-weight band, not a number**: Tan Tien Flex 1 covers **170 to 270lb**, Flex 2 covers **110 to 210**. A ninety-kilogram rider who buys the softer flex gets a deck that sags, loses pump energy and eventually cracks at the drop-through neck.⁴

THE CHATTER · THE WHITE-LABEL POINT, INVERTED

In cycling, two differently priced bikes share one frame and nobody says so. Here the opposite is true and everyone is cheerful about it: **a Pantheon complete ships on Paris trucks and the maker's own wheels; a Loaded complete ships on Paris trucks and Orangatang wheels; a Loaded Fathom ships on another company's brackets entirely**. The components are the stars and the brands admit it on the product page. Which is also why the LDP split-angle argument — a steeper truck at the front, a shallower one behind — now arrives pre-assembled: the standard dealer build of one popular commuter pairs a **150mm 50-degree** front with a **150mm 43-degree** rear, and the buyer never has to learn why.⁴

THE SCEPTIC · "TAKEN WITH A PINCH OF SALT"

The sport's own equipment reviewer, **Pierre-Edouard Duedal** of the UK Ultraskate, is blunter about bearings than any outsider would dare: **"these ABEC ratings are often negligible as this is not always reflective of performance"**, and on ceramics, **"Ceramics will last longer in principle, but this will be dependent on how the board is typically handled, and maintenance."** On wheel marketing generally: bold claims **"that spur week long debates"** and **"it all often needs to be taken with a pinch of salt."** He recommends a **US\$15.99** bearing over a **\$125** ceramic one at the same job — and, to his credit, publishes the fact that his sponsors include a truck maker and a bushing maker. On a **US\$80** truck from one newer brand, his verdict is the sentence that describes this whole cottage industry: the reviews are decent and the price hard to ignore, but the alloy is not the grade claimed by its rivals and he cannot tell whether the maker is **"authentic or a copycat"** — **"the waters feels very muddled."**⁵

\$15.99 v \$125

THE BEARINGS THE SPORT'S OWN REVIEWER RECOMMENDS,
AGAINST THE CERAMICS HE DOES NOT⁵

SOURCES 1 The forum's host returned a server error on repeated attempts across this session, which is reported as its current state rather than as closure. The archive site's own pages, read at source, for its history, its continuing updates into late September 2026, its subscriber count and the quoted description of where the scene went. 2 The two subreddits' own listing endpoints, read at source on 10 October 2026, for post volume, scores, comment counts and thread titles; the third served no posts, which is reported as dormancy rather than deletion. Subscriber counts were not readable and none are printed. 3 Construction definitions as given by the makers' own specifications; the two ride heights are a Singapore retailer's own published comparison. 4 Makers' own shop pages, read at source on 10 October 2026, for every price quoted, the complete builds and their component makes, the truck angles in the standard dealer build, and the flex bands as the maker publishes them. 5 The UK Ultraskate equipment reviews of April 2024, read at source; all quotations are verbatim, the bearing recommendation and prices are his, the sponsor disclosure is published on his own pages, and the uncertainty about one maker's provenance is his own stated position.

Here is the finding that makes this desk worth a Singapore reader's time, and it is the opposite of what the rest of the world reports. Everywhere else, electric boards have eaten the commuting case — the argument is live in the distance room this week, one rider weighing a push setup against an e-board at much the same money. In Singapore the law settled it the other way. Under the transport authority's own device matrix a **non-motorised personal mobility device — explicitly skateboards and kick-scooters — may be ridden on cycling paths AND footpaths, with no registration, no theory test and no minimum age.** A motorised one may use **cycling paths only**, must carry a **UL2272** certificate, and the rider must be **sixteen**.¹

Read that twice if you have a child of twelve. The pushed board has strictly **more** legal path access here than the electric one, and a parent and a Secondary 1 child can legally ride the same footpaths and park connectors together on pushed boards — which they could not do on e-scooters. The e-board did not win the commute in Singapore. The law fenced it.¹

The rest of the local reality is heat and surface. East Coast Park is the named stretch — paved, flat, much of it lit — though one listings guide warns it is **“more suited to laidback cyclists rather than speed demons”** with children and skaters across the path. The threads have already solved it without being asked: the distance room's own post titles this fortnight are **“Out before the sunrise”, “Flashlights on Friday”** and **“Midnight Marathon”**. Skate commuting here is a dawn-and-dusk sport.²

So what does it cost? Honestly, less than almost any gear hobby this magazine has covered — and that is the point and the trap. A complete, properly specified, is **US\$340 to \$390**. The meaningful upgrades after that are bushings and bearings, which run in tens of dollars. The money pit, where it exists, is precision trucks sold **one at a time at S\$250 to S\$635 each**, so a pair is a four-figure decision, and adjustable baseplates at **\$395** that most riders set once and never touch. The sport's own reviewer flags one pair at **\$1,600** that is not even intended for this discipline.³

SOURCES 1 The Land Transport Authority's own device matrix in its published handbook, pages 13 to 14, for the path access, registration, testing and age rules distinguishing non-motorised from motorised personal mobility devices, and for the certification requirement; the quoted rule that all such devices may use cycling paths but only non-motorised ones may use footpaths is the handbook's own. The comparison with the electric board is this desk's. The live community argument about electric boards is from two posts on the distance subreddit dated 6 October 2026, read at source. 2 A listings guide's published description of the East Coast stretch, quoted as written, and the post titles of the distance subreddit over the fortnight to 10 October 2026, read at source. The observation about surfaces is this desk's inference and is not sourced. 3 Complete prices from the makers' own shop pages; the precision-truck and baseplate prices from a Singapore retailer's own listings; the figure for one pair not intended for the discipline is the sport's own reviewer's. 4 The community gear writer's beginner guidance of 11 April 2024, read at source, including the warning quoted; the body-maintenance detail and the fall are from the posts quoted on the first page of this desk, in their authors' own words. 5 The dead or frozen sites listed were each tested this session and are reported in the state they returned; the two blogs' last-post dates are as published on them; the stock quotation is a British shop's own trading note of 25 September 2026; the newcomer's line is a post of 7 October 2026 read at source.

THE CHATTER · THE FIRST NINETY DAYS, HONESTLY

Skip the cheap rung: the community's own gear writer **warns against cheap generic drop-throughs** outright. Buy one complete from a maker that publishes its flex bands, matched to your weight, and change nothing for a month. Then buy bushings, which are the cheapest real upgrade, before you consider anything else. Lurk in the distance subreddit rather than the mass one — the answer rate is extraordinary and the register is kind. Expect the body to be the limiting factor: the forty-four-year-old whose posts open this desk spent his second week asking the internet for **exercises for the soles of his feet**, because repetitive single-leg pushing is what actually hurts. And expect, early, one slow fall onto a hip from a pebble you did not see.⁴

THE SCEPTIC · THE HOBBY'S PROBLEM IS NOT COST

Where gravel cyclists complain their sport got rich, longboarders complain that theirs got thin — and the evidence is a list of dead links. The great forum returns a server error. One famous deck brand's domain does not resolve at all. Another's site is frozen at a 2023 copyright line with no readable prices. The governing body's news stopped in **January 2025**; the best equipment blog in the sport stopped in **July 2024** with no next event dated. A British shop reports the flagship wheels unobtainable across Europe **“for the foreseeable future”**. And a newcomer this month writes simply: **“the market seems pretty small.”** The honest sceptical line is not that this hobby is expensive, because it is not. It is that the supply chain and the institutions are fragile, and that the upgrade culture is a treadmill of small decisions dressed as engineering. Two things would falsify it: a dated next edition of the British twenty-four-hour race, and the flagship wheels back in European stock.⁵

NEXT DESCENTS

Lockpicking & physical-security sport — a graded belt ladder, and a legal line that moves at the border.

Bookbinding & book repair — coptic to case, bone folders, and an archival-materials rabbit hole.

Home cheesemaking — cultures, rennet and a cave in a tropical flat.

FITNESS • FRAGMENTATION

Not how much you move — how readily you stop

Half a million treadmill tests produced the week's biggest number and its smallest gain. A study a hundredth the size found something more useful.

The headline arrived on **6 October** and it is enormous: **562,234 adults**, mean follow-up **10.2 years**, and each additional **MET** of measured cardiorespiratory fitness carrying a **16 per cent** lower hazard of death — hazard ratio **0.84**. Ten-year mortality, adjusted, came out at **32.9 per cent** among the least fit and **13.4** among the fit.¹

Now read the numbers against each other, which the abstract does not do for you. “Unfit” is defined as the lowest quintile, **below 5.0 METs** — a threshold a conditioned man in his forties clears several times over. So the 32.9-against-13.4 contrast is not good fitness versus excellent; it is largely the already-ill against the well. The cohort is a clinical referral population: half a million people who were sent for a treadmill test. And subclinical disease lowers peak METs years before it kills, which no observational design can separate from fitness protecting you.¹

Then the number that should govern the page. Adding fitness to the standard risk factors moved the model's discrimination from a C-statistic of **0.662 to 0.682 — two percentage points**, across 562,234 people, and both figures mediocre. The confidence interval of **0.838 to 0.842** is an artefact of the sample size, not precision about any individual. A very large study has told us something true and small.¹

The more useful finding came from a study a hundredth the size. Pooled accelerometer data on **5,973 American adults**, median follow-up **14.4 years**, **1,429 deaths**, with the exposure being the **probability that activity gives way to rest**. Each standard deviation of extra fragmentation carried **HR 1.19 (1.09–1.30)** — while total volume stayed protective at **0.83 (0.75–0.92)** in the same model. Fragmentation added more to a model containing volume than volume added to one containing fragmentation.²

SOURCES 1 Myers and colleagues, “Cardiorespiratory Fitness Reclassifies Mortality Risk Beyond Traditional Risk Factors”, *Medicine and Science in Sports and Exercise*, published online 6 October 2026, read as its abstract record at the National Library of Medicine: sample size, design, exposure and the definition of the least-fit quintile, follow-up, the per-MET hazard ratio and its interval, the reclassification and discrimination statistics, and the adjusted ten-year mortality figures. The observations about the referral cohort, the threshold and reverse causation are this desk's reading of that design. 2 Gruda, “Red light, green light: activity fragmentation and all-cause mortality in United States adults”, *Annals of Epidemiology*, 26 September 2026, read as its abstract record: the pooled accelerometer samples, the analytic size, follow-up and deaths, the exposure definition and both hazard ratios with intervals. It is a single-author paper on fewer than six thousand people with a short exposure window, and is treated here as hypothesis-generating. 3 Attia, Nelson and Yeater, published 29 August 2026 and read at source, for the talk-test definition quoted verbatim, the stated reason for preferring it to tracker zones, and the training ratios by weekly hours including the two-hour case. The bout-length translation is this desk's, from the fragmentation paper above. 4 Attia with Yeater and Birkenbach, published 17 January 2026 and read at source; the three quotations are verbatim, and the objection to mutually adjusted regressions is his. The authorship overlap between that paper's target and the reallocation study cited here was checked against both author lists. 5 Bian and colleagues, “Reallocation of 24-hour movement behaviour composition and mortality”, *American Journal of Epidemiology*, 7 October 2026, read as its abstract record: the cohort size, deaths and follow-up, and each reallocation hazard ratio with its confidence interval, for participants meeting and not meeting sleep-duration guidelines.

THE CHATTER • THREE THINGS TO ACTUALLY DO

Use speech, not the watch. Peter Attia's own framing of easy aerobic work is that you are in it when “**you can still speak in complete sentences, but you'd rather not carry on a conversation**” — and his stated reason for preferring the talk test is that tracker heart-rate zones are inconsistent, which is worth hearing if you own two of them. **Scale the ratio to the hours you have.** At seven or eight hours a week, mostly easy. At six, about four hours easy and two hard. At **two hours — the realistic case — skip dedicated easy work entirely** and do two hard sessions: thirty minutes of one-on, one-off, and four-minutes-on, four-off. **Lengthen the bouts.** On the fragmentation model the win is fewer, longer movements rather than more scattered ones.³

THE SCEPTIC • AND IT IS ATTIA AGAIN

The strongest objection to this page comes from the longevity scene's own principal, writing against exactly this class of study. “**Movement was measured over just three to seven days at some point in the study and then used to model outcomes years later**”; “**accelerometers measure movement, not physiological load**”; “**all intensities of movement matter, but they are not interchangeable**”. His further point is the sharpest: mutually adjusted regressions do not simulate anyone actually swapping one behaviour for another, so they cannot license a replacement claim. That applies to both supporting studies here, and the overlap is literal — three authors of the reallocation paper are co-authors of the work he was attacking.⁴

Education, not a clinical opinion. The honest synthesis is unglamorous: volume still matters, continuity may matter more than the step count suggests, and the largest study of the week improved a prediction model by two points.

DEPARTURES • THE CROSSING

A third date for the shuttle nobody has ridden

The Johor link slipped again on 2 October, from January to February. Everything built is built; what is missing is a safety certificate.

The Land Transport Authority published it plainly on **2 October**: the grantors have been told by the operator that passenger service on the **Johor Bahru–Singapore Rapid Transit System Link** is “**now expected to commence in February 2027**”, subject to independent safety certification and final approvals from both countries. The operator expects to finish system tests and trial runs by **31 December 2026**.¹

Count the dates: **end-2026, then January 2027, now February**. The third slip. What makes this one different from a construction delay is that there is nothing left to build — the works either side are described as substantially complete. The gap is certification, which is a signature, not a viaduct.¹

The other thing that moved is cheaper and permanent. Singapore’s **Sustainable Aviation Fuel levy** now applies to tickets **sold from 1 October 2026** for flights **departing from 1 January 2027**, and it must appear as a distinct line in the fare breakdown rather than vanish into the total. The bands are flat per passenger: **S\$1.00** economy to Southeast Asia, **S\$2.80** to Northeast Asia, South Asia and Australia, **S\$6.40** to Europe, the Middle East and Africa, **S\$10.40** to the Americas — and four times each figure in premium cabins. Transit passengers are exempt; this is an origin-and-destination charge. Cargo is deferred a year.²

Two pounds eighty on a Tokyo ticket, printed as its own line so you cannot miss it.

And the Japanese shopping rebate everyone has been waiting on has **not** moved. The at-till exemption runs to **31 October 2026**; from the first of **November** the price you hand over includes the tax and you reclaim

it on departure. The threshold stays **¥5,000** before tax, per shop, per day. What changes is better than the headline suggests: the consumables-versus-general-goods split goes, the **¥500,000** consumables cap goes, sealed packaging goes, and the purchase window becomes a single **90 days** before departure. The catch is procedural — you clear a tax-free terminal before bag drop, and inspection is per receipt, so one missing item voids that whole receipt.³

THE SCEPTIC • THE AIRPORT CONTRADICTS ITS OWN TABLE

An audit published on **10 October** counted **42 airlines** at Changi offering some form of early check-in, with **Singapore Airlines accepting bags up to 48 hours** ahead at Terminals 2 and 3. Changi Airport Group’s own page lists **25 airlines** and gives Singapore Airlines as **3 to 24 hours**. Worse, the group’s own frequently-asked-questions page says bag drop is “**typically 12 to 24 hours**” ahead, which contradicts the three-hour minimum printed in its own table one scroll above. The page carries **no last-updated date**, which is how a table and its footnote drift apart unnoticed. Two airlines — Air India and British Airways — have quietly left the Jewel early check-in list. Go by the airline, not the airport.⁴

Feb 2027

THE THIRD TARGET DATE FOR THE JOHOR LINK, AFTER END-2026 AND JANUARY¹

S\$2.80

THE FUEL LEVY ON AN ECONOMY TICKET TO NORTHEAST ASIA, FROM 1 JANUARY²

One correction to the standing furniture of Singapore travel writing, this desk included: **Jetstar Asia no longer exists**. It ceased operations on **31 July 2025**. Any list of “the carriers a Singapore flyer uses” that still carries it is copying an older list.⁵

SOURCES 1 The Land Transport Authority’s own news release of 2 October 2026 on the rapid transit link, read at source: the February 2027 expectation and its quoted wording, the conditions of independent safety certification and regulatory approval, the 31 December 2026 testing target, and the statement that infrastructure works are substantially complete. The earlier targets are from the authority’s and the transport ministry’s previous published positions. 2 The Civil Aviation Authority of Singapore’s own newsroom releases of 3 September 2026 for the revised timetable and the line-item requirement, and of 10 November 2025 for the full band table of per-passenger amounts and the transit exemption; the cargo deferral is from the former. 3 The Japan Tourism Agency’s own pages on the tax-free system, read at source for the 31 October 2026 cut-over, the refund mechanism, the unchanged ¥5,000 threshold, the abolition of the consumables split and cap, the 90-day purchase window and the per-receipt inspection. 4 An aviation specialist’s audit of Changi early check-in published 10 October 2026, against Changi Airport Group’s own early-check-in page and its frequently-asked questions, both read at source on 11 October; the airline counts, the 48-hour and 3-to-24-hour figures and the internal contradiction are as published on those pages. 5 The carrier ceased operations on 31 July 2025 following its parent’s announcement of 11 June 2025; this is secondary and the final flight details are not printed here.

DEPARTURES · SEATS, LOUNGES & POINTS

Riyadh slips to March; Dubai overtakes it

Singapore Airlines has moved one Gulf launch twice and quietly re-sequenced the other. Meanwhile a lounge closes in Taipei and a transfer partner vanishes without notice.

The Riyadh launch has moved again. **SQ498/499** is now targeted at **28 March 2027** — the first day of the northern summer season — at **three weekly** rather than the planned four, on an A350 Medium Haul with the 2018 regional business seat. The previous target was 1 December 2026; the original was 2 June 2026. Weekly capacity each way falls to **120 business and 789 economy** seats, from 160 and 1,052.¹

Dubai, meanwhile, has overtaken it. The cancellation window for **SQ494/495** now runs only to **1 December 2026**, implying a restart around **2 December** — nearly four months ahead of Riyadh, and stepping up to a 777-300ER from late March. Both of these are reported rather than announced: the airline's own newsroom paths returned nothing to this desk, and the specialist reporting it says plainly that March is a target, not a certainty.¹

Closer to home, two losses and one gain. The **SilverKris Lounge at Taipei Taoyuan** closes after **31 October**, the airline citing Terminal 2 redevelopment, with eligible passengers sent to a contract lounge on Level 4 and no replacement announced. The advisory avoids the word “permanently”. **Gulf Air** starts a daily Singapore to Kuala Lumpur fifth-freedom on **26 October** on a 787-9, seventy minutes gate to gate, **282 seats** including twenty-six in a 2-2-2 suite cabin, loaded through September 2027, with returns from about **S\$246** in economy and **S\$1,025** in business.²

The partnership ran for six years. It ended in a revised terms page at seven in the evening.

And the points move is the one to act on. **DBS has dropped Qantas Frequent Flyer** as a transfer partner — the option disappeared from the rewards portal in late September, and the bank confirmed it only in revised terms published around **7pm on 1 October**,

with the last references gone by the 3rd. The partnership had run since **March 2019**. What remains transfers at **5,000 points to 10,000 miles** to KrisFlyer and to Asia Miles. For anyone still wanting Qantas miles out of Singapore, the best ratio now is **25,000 bank points to 10,000 Qantas points**, no fee, with one other issuer.³

THE CHATTER · THE CABIN THAT HALVED WHILE NOBODY LOOKED

For the winter season, Singapore Airlines has cut First Class to Jakarta from four daily rotations to **two — eight seats a day each way, down from sixteen**, and roughly **1,200 fewer** across the season. In winter 2019–20 the figure was **forty a day**. The two surviving rotations use the 777-300ER with the 2013 four-seat cabin; the other seven are A350s with no First at all. The stated driver is fleet: the 777-300ER count is down by one and those aircraft have gone to Frankfurt and Auckland. Hong Kong drops to a single daily First on the same date. The replacement First Class is not due until **mid-to-late 2027**.⁴

16 → 8

DAILY FIRST CLASS SEATS EACH WAY TO JAKARTA THIS WINTER; FORTY A DAY IN 2019⁴

IN BRIEF

Terminal 5 — still “**the middle of the 2030s**”. Ground broken May 2025, substructure and airfield contracts let in the first half of that year, superstructure tender imminent. Phase one is designed for about **50 million** passengers a year with headroom to **70 million**, inside the 1,080-hectare Changi East site.⁵

Scoot — Guiyang three times weekly from **26 October** on an A320neo, per the carrier's media centre as surfaced in search; the site itself refused this desk, so treat it as unconfirmed.⁶

Entry rules — the European Union's own travel pages returned errors on every attempt this week, as did Bali's levy portal. This desk prints no ETIAS date, no entry-system window and no Bali figure rather than repeat one from memory.⁶

SOURCES 1 Specialist aviation reporting of 8 October 2026 on the Riyadh schedule and of 1 October 2026 on the Dubai restart, including the flight numbers, the seasonal start dates, the frequency and cabin configuration and the weekly capacity figures. No carrier release is cited by either report and the airline's own advisory and newsroom paths were unreachable from this desk; the March 2027 date is described by its author as a target rather than a certainty, and is printed here on that basis. 2 Reporting of 5 October 2026 by two independent specialist outlets quoting the airline's lounge advisory consistently, the airline's own advisory page being unreachable here; and reporting of 6 October 2026 for the Gulf Air service, its aircraft, cabin, block time, seat count, loaded period and indicative return fares, for which no carrier release is cited. 3 Reporting of 8 October 2026 on the withdrawal of the Qantas transfer option, the timing of the revised terms, the duration of the partnership, the surviving transfer ratios and the alternative issuer ratios. 4 Reporting of 6 October 2026 on the northern winter season, with the rotation and seat counts, the seasonal reduction, the 2019–20 comparison, the aircraft types, the stated fleet driver and the timing of the replacement cabin. 5 The transport ministry's written reply on Terminal 5, page last updated 8 October 2026, and the airport operator's own project page, both read at source. 6 The carrier's media centre could not be read directly — every path returned a refusal — and the European and Indonesian official pages returned server errors; both are reported here as unverified rather than printed as fact.

THE GRAND TOUR · OKINAWA & MIYAKOJIMA

Two in three of Japan's typhoons come here

The islands sit under the storm track, and the published normals show the escape clearly: August runs 2.3 approaches a month, November 0.3.

Start with the number that decides the trip. The Japan Meteorological Agency's 1991–2020 normals count **11.7 typhoons approaching Japan** in an average year — and **7.9 of them** pass within 300 kilometres of Okinawa and Amami. Two in three. These islands are not merely in the typhoon zone; they are the zone.¹

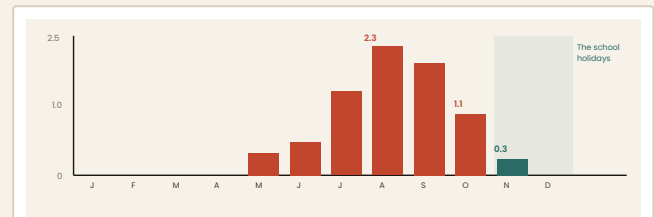
The same table holds the escape. Approaches peak in **August at 2.3 a month** — not September, as the folklore has it, which runs 2.0. Then it falls off a cliff: **October 1.1, November 0.3**. From the August peak to November is a **seven-fold** reduction. That is not a feeling about shoulder season; it is the agency's own arithmetic, and it points at exactly one window.¹

Naha's climate normals agree, and contain a genuine surprise. **September is the wettest month at 275mm** — wetter than August's 240mm, and wetter than May's 245mm, which falls inside the rainy season proper. The tsuyu is not Okinawa's wettest period. November, by contrast, runs **119mm**, the second-driest month of the year, at a daily maximum still averaging **25.0°C**, with the sea around **27°C** in October. The rainy season itself opens about **10 May** and ends about **21 June**; this year it ran 4 May to 29 June, a week past normal.²

The holiday window sits in the trough. That is luck, and it is worth spending.

Which lands on a date. **Shuri Castle's Seiden reopens on Monday 23 November 2026**, seven years after the 2019 fire, with a completion ceremony the day before. Entry to the interior is **advance reservation only, in thirty-minute timed slots**, with a visitor cap the park says plainly is there to prevent overtourism; group interior bookings are refused outright from 23 November to 6 December. New

admission is **¥1,000** for an adult, ¥760 for high school, ¥370 for younger children. Slots for 23 November to 31 December went on sale on **1 September and 1 October**, so by the time you read this they may be gone.³



Typhoons approaching within 300km of Okinawa and Amami, by month: the Japan Meteorological Agency's own 1991–2020 normals, charted by *Meridian*. The shaded band is Singapore's year-end school holiday, 21 November to 31 December.¹

THE CHATTER · ONE NIGHT IN NAHA, THEN TAKE THE CAR

The TripAdvisor Okinawa boards converge on three things, and the threads are old enough to say so. **A car is worth it for everything outside Naha** — public transport is repeatedly called poor for visitors, leaving the carless confined to the monorail, buses and taxis. **Naha is a one-night stop, not a base**: one poster goes as far as calling it the ugliest city in Japan, while others defend it for Shuri and the urban mix; the recurring advice is a night there without a car, then collect one and move on. And **book the car far ahead** — supply has been tight since the pandemic and larger vehicles go first, which matters for a family. The dissent is specific: one poster reports a dispute over a scratch and warns off third-party booking sites, another found a small local operator cheap. Read the damage terms.⁴

7.9 of 11.7

TYPHOONS APPROACHING JAPAN EACH YEAR THAT COME WITHIN 300KM OF OKINAWA¹

And the document that strands people is not the treaty. Singapore is a party to the 1949 Geneva Convention, and Japan accepts its permits — the trap is the paperwork, which page two takes apart.

SOURCES 1 The Japan Meteorological Agency's own table of typhoon normals for 1991–2020, read at source: formation, approach to Japan, approach to Okinawa and Amami, and landfall, by month and for the year. The seven-fold August-to-November comparison and the two-in-three share are this desk's arithmetic from that table. 2 The same agency's climate normals for Naha, 1991–2020, read at source for monthly mean, maximum and minimum temperature, rainfall and sunshine; and its own record of rainy-season onset and withdrawal dates for Okinawa, for the 1991–2020 normals and for the 2024, 2025 and 2026 actuals. The October sea temperature is the Okinawan tourism board's own published figure; this desk has only six of twelve monthly values from an official source and prints no annual curve. 3 Shurijo Castle Park's own notices, read at source: the notice of 4 June 2026 for the completion ceremony of 22 November and the public opening of 23 November 2026, and the notice of 31 July 2026 for the admission fees, the thirty-minute timed-slot reservation system, the stated purpose of the visitor cap, the refusal of group interior bookings between 23 November and 6 December, and the two ticket-release dates. 4 Threads on the TripAdvisor Okinawa destination forums. These were surfaced and summarised through search; the pages themselves refused this desk, so the positions above are attributed paraphrase of thread content rather than verbatim quotation, and most of the threads are several years old.

The car is not optional outside Naha, and the thing that stops people is a stamp. Japan's National Police Agency, in guidance published 7 May 2026, accepts "**an International Driving Permit pursuant to the 1949 Geneva Convention on Road Traffic**", and separately recognises foreign licences only from countries that issue no permit at all — **Switzerland, Germany, France, Belgium, Monaco and Taiwan**, as at 1 April 2026. Singapore is not on that list, and does not need to be: it has been a party to the 1949 Convention since **29 November 1972**, and Japan acceded in 1964.¹

So the permit works — and then the details bite. Asked whether a digital permit on a phone will do, the agency's own question-and-answer sheet says: "**No, that is not possible.**" The format is fixed at **148 by 105 millimetres**. Above all the vehicle-category column must carry a **stamp**: "**If you do not have a sticker or stamp in any of the vehicle type columns, you will not be able to drive in Japan.**" A tick is not a stamp, and a larger category does not cover a smaller one.²

In practice: a permit from the Automobile Association of Singapore, the sole issuer, at **S\$20**, valid a year, carried as **paper** with the physical licence and passport. Get it before you fly; one cannot be issued in Japan. A 1968 Vienna Convention permit is not accepted.³

The failure is never the treaty. It is an unstamped box, or a permit left on a phone.

Then the islands. **Churaumi Aquarium** is **¥2,180** adult, **¥710** for a primary or junior-high child; its own site publishes a **live congestion percentage**, which beats any rule of thumb about mornings. **Miyakojima** is a separate flight and a separate holiday: **Japan Transocean Air and ANA only** from Naha, about **fifty-five minutes**. Skymark does not fly it, whatever the aggregators say. The **Irabu Bridge** runs **3,540 metres**, opened **31 January 2015**, cost about **¥40 billion** — and is widely called Japan's longest toll-free

bridge, a claim the prefecture's own project page does not make. We print the length, not the superlative.⁴

THE SCEPTIC · THE BLUE ZONE IS AGEING OUT

Okinawan longevity is the most-sold fact about these islands, and Japan's own health ministry has quietly undone half of it. In the **2020 prefectural life tables**, life expectancy at birth for **Okinawan men is 80.73 years — 43rd of 47 prefectures**, below the national 81.49. Women reach **87.88, 16th of 47**. And yet at **age 75 Okinawan men rank second in Japan**, 12.93 further years, behind only Nagano — the ministry itself notes Okinawa among the prefectures rising most sharply between the two ages. That is not a debunking but a dating: the cohort already old is extraordinary, the cohort being born is not. The diet tourism sells one generation's habits as a property of the place. The louder critique — that supercentenarian records reflect clerical error and pension fraud — rests on a preprint, and is not needed: the government's own tables do the work.⁵

43rd of 47

OKINAWAN MALE LIFE EXPECTANCY AT BIRTH; SECOND IN JAPAN FROM AGE 75⁵

BEFORE YOU BOOK

The window. Term four ends **20 November** and the holidays run to 31 December. But **21–23 November** is the worst-crowded weekend of the Okinawan year — a Japanese public holiday on the Monday, the Seiden opening the same day, the park closed for the ceremony on the Sunday. Fly **24 or 25 November** and you dodge the long weekend with the hall newly open.³

The market. **Dai-ichi Makishi Public Market**, rebuilt **March 2023**, keeps the practice: buy fish or meat from the **75 ground-floor shops**, carry it upstairs, pay to have it cooked. The cooking service's **last order is 7.45pm** — the detail nobody prints.⁶

Held, not guessed. This desk could not read a Scoot fare, a Rosewood nightly rate or a car-hire price at any source it trusts, and prints none. The yen has **firmed about 1.2 per cent** against the Singapore dollar since No. 79 — **¥125.1 to ¥123.6** — so the soft-yen trade has stopped improving.⁷

One more honest subtraction: the Rosewood on Miyako is not news. It opened in **March 2025** and has been trading ever since.⁷

SOURCES 1 Japan's National Police Agency guidance for foreign licence holders, published 7 May 2026 and read as its own document: the categories of acceptable licence, the quoted wording on 1949 Convention permits, and the list of recognised translation countries as at 1 April 2026. Singapore's succession to the 1949 Convention on 29 November 1972 and Japan's accession in 1964 are from the United Nations treaty register. 2 The same agency's published question-and-answer sheet for permit holders, quoted directly: the refusal of digital permits, the prescribed dimensions, the stamped-category requirement and the validity period. 3 The Automobile Association of Singapore's own permit page for the fee, validity and non-renewability, with the police force's own guidance on the licence; the Japanese school-holiday and public-holiday dates are from the Cabinet Office's own calendar, and the Singapore school dates from a Ministry of Education school calendar read at source. 4 Churaumi Aquarium's own visitor-information pages for admission and hours and for the live congestion display; Skymark's own route network page for the Miyako service; and Okinawa Prefecture's own project page for the Irabu Bridge's length, opening date and cost — a page which makes no superlative claim and does not mention tolls. 5 Japan's Ministry of Health, Labour and Welfare, 2020 prefectural life tables, read as the ministry's own published document: life expectancy at birth and rank by sex for Okinawa, the national figures, the comparator prefectures, the remaining life expectancy at 75 and the ministry's own remark on prefectures whose ranking rises between the two ages. The competing supercentenarian critique is a preprint and is identified as such. 6 Naha City's own page for the public market, read at source: the rebuilding and reopening, the shop count, opening hours and the cooking service's last order. 7 Exchange rates derived by this desk from the European Central Bank's own euro reference rates for 21 August and 9 October 2026; the derivation is ours. The hotel's opening date and current trading status are from its own property page.

THE DIARY · THE DATED AGENDA

One on-sale falls inside this week. Set an alarm

Nothing here is printed on an aggregator's word alone. Six listings could not be stood up at a primary source and are named at the foot.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

13–22 NOV ★ **Singapore Writers Festival — Hidden in Plain Sight**
VICTORIA THEATRE, THE ARTS HOUSE, NATIONAL GALLERY · THE ONLY ENTRY HERE WITH PUBLISHED PRICES: **FESTIVAL PASS \$24** EARLY BIRD (USUAL \$30), **YOUTH PASS \$12** (USUAL \$15), EACH COVERING 100-PLUS PROGRAMMES · **ON SALE NOW, NO PUBLISHED CUT-OFF**¹

31 OCT **TEMALANG**
ESPLANADE · MARKING **50 YEARS** OF SINGAPORE DIKIR BARAT · PRICES NOT PUBLISHED ON THE FESTIVALS INDEX²

3 NOV **yung kai — Asia Tour 2026**
CAPITOL THEATRE, 8PM · GENERAL SALE LISTED, VIP PACKAGES AVAILABLE · NO PRICES ON THE PROMOTER'S PAGE³

20–29 NOV **Kalaa Utsavam — Indian Festival of Arts**
ESPLANADE · TEN DAYS OF MUSIC AND DANCE · PRICES NOT PUBLISHED ON THE INDEX PAGE²

3–6 DEC **Voices — A Festival of Song**
ESPLANADE · CHORAL, A CAPPELLA, MUSICAL THEATRE AND OPERA · PRICES NOT YET PUBLISHED²

22–24 JAN **ART SG, fifth edition**
SANDS EXPO · VIP PREVIEW AND VERNISSAGE **21 JAN** · **STILL NO PUBLIC TICKET PRICE PUBLISHED** — THE SITE CARRIES ONLY THE GALLERY APPLICATION⁴

4 APR ★ **beabadoobee — The Powerlines Tour**
INDOOR STADIUM, 8PM, 2027 · **ARTIST PRESALE MON 12 OCT NOON**, MASTERCARD TUE 13TH 2PM, PROMOTER PRESALE WED 14TH NOON (REGISTRATION REQUIRED), **GENERAL SALE THU 15 OCT NOON** · PRICES NOT PUBLISHED³

13–18 APR **Bruno Mars — The Romantic Tour**
NATIONAL STADIUM, 2027 — FOUR NIGHTS: **13, 14, 17, 18 APRIL** (THE PROMOTER'S HEADER RENDERS A CONTINUOUS RANGE; THE INFO BLOCK GIVES THE FOUR DATES) · ON-SALE AND PRICES UNPUBLISHED³

JAPAN & THE REGION

THE ONES WITH A TICKET CLOCK

10–24 JAN ★ **Grand Sumo, Hatsu Basho**
RYŌGOKU KOKUGIKAN, TOKYO, 2027 · **ADVANCE SALE OPENS SAT 5 DECEMBER** · THE PRECEDENT IS BRUTAL: NOVEMBER'S KYUSHU BASHO OPENED ON 19 SEP AND THE OFFICIAL AGENT NOW SAYS **"TICKETS ARE SOLD OUT ALL DATES"**⁵

11–13 DEC ★ **Tokyo Comic Con, tenth anniversary**
MAKUHARI, CHIBA · **3-DAY PASS ¥9,900**; ADVANCE ONE-DAY **¥5,500** GENERAL, **¥1,000** UNDER-18, **¥500** UNDER-15 · PHOTO AND AUTOGRAPH TICKETS RUN **¥23,000–¥48,000** AND ARE THE REAL EXPENSE⁶

31 OCT–28 MAR **Mariko Mori — All That Shines**
MORI ART MUSEUM, ROPPONGI · THE MUSEUM HAS BEEN **CLOSED SINCE 24 SEP** AND REOPENS WITH IT · ADMISSION NOT PUBLISHED ON THE ENGLISH LANDING PAGE⁷

2–3 DEC **Chichibu Yomatsuri**
CHICHIBU SHRINE, SAITAMA · EVE FESTIVAL THE 2ND, MAIN THE 3RD, PEAKING **7PM TO 10PM** · NO TICKETING MENTIONED · THE OFFICIAL PAGE STATES FIXED ANNUAL DATES WITHOUT NAMING THE YEAR⁸

31 OCT–7 NOV **Melbourne Cup Carnival**
FLEMINGTON · FOUR RACE DAYS: **31 OCT, 3, 5 AND 7 NOV** · THE CLUB'S PAGE DOES NOT LABEL EACH DATE, SO THE CONVENTIONAL ORDER IS GIVEN AS CONVENTION · NO PRICES ON THE LANDING PAGE⁹

11–31 JAN **Australian Open 2027**
MELBOURNE · A **21-DAY** SPAN INCLUDING QUALIFYING · SOLD THROUGH THE AUSTRALIAN TICKETING AGENT, **NO ON-SALE DATE PUBLISHED**⁹

7 MAR **Tokyo Marathon 2027 — and you have missed it**
THE TWENTIETH EDITION · GENERAL ENTRY **CLOSED 28 AUGUST 2026**, BALLOT DRAWN · VOLUNTEER REGISTRATION RUNS **6 OCT TO 23 NOV** — THE REMAINING WAY IN¹⁰

9–11 APR **Hong Kong Sevens**
KAI TAK STADIUM, 2027 · THE OFFICIAL SITE SAYS ONLY **"TICKETING DETAILS TO FOLLOW"** — WATCH FOR THE BALLOT¹¹

SOURCES Failed verification and dropped: Christmas Wonderland at Gardens by the Bay (absent from the gardens' own site and ticketing); the Singapore marathon (its site still serves 2025 content with no 2026 date); Halloween Horror Nights (the resort page returns an error); and four concert dates that appear only in aggregators, whose artist pages render nothing and whose sellers return no results — aggregators also contradict each other on whether one is sold out. A fifth, a November concert, is promoter-confirmed by date but its venue could not be read, so it is not listed. 1 The festival's own site, read at source, for dates, venues, both pass prices and the early-bird framing. 2 Esplanade's own festivals and series index, read at source, for the three festival dates and the absence of published prices. 3 The promoter's own event pages, read at source, for the dates, venues, times and the full presale ladder; prices are not published on those pages and none are printed. 4 The fair's own site, read at source. 5 The official ticket agent of the sumo association and the association's own English site, read at source, for the January dates, the advance-sale date and the quoted sold-out notice for November. 6 The organiser's own ticket page, read at source, for all prices quoted, which are tax-inclusive. 7 The museum's own English site, read at source. 8 The Chichibu tourism association's own festival page, read at source; it gives the festival's fixed annual dates and does not name the year, which is stated in the row. 9 The racing club's own ticketing pages and the tournament's own site, read at source. 10 The marathon's own site, read at source, for the closed entry window and the volunteer dates. 11 The tournament's own site, read at source.

THE TABLE · OCTOBER'S OPENINGS

Six rooms open. Not one has been reviewed

Four of these carry confirmation at the venue's own site and prices it publishes itself. What none of them carries yet is a verdict from anybody who paid.

Singapore has opened a great deal this month and judged almost none of it. Start with the two hotel rooms. **Tanica**, at The Singapore EDITION on Cuscaden Road, replaces the hotel's previous restaurant with **"a lofty space celebrating modern Asian cuisine"** — sharing plates off the Jospo or the wok. The only figure it publishes is **\$88++** for a bottle of Champagne shared between four on a Wednesday; the weekday set lunch and the Sunday service carry no price. There is no online booking path — a telephone number and an email address. Trade coverage names a chef and a September opening; the hotel's own page names neither.¹

Sophia, at The St. Regis on Tanglin Road, is the better-documented of the pair and the cheaper way in. A glasshouse-inspired room, Italian across **eleven regions**, with chef de cuisine **Angelo Sergio** named on the restaurant's site though not the hotel's. It publishes a real number: **set lunch from S\$42** for two courses. Go at weekday lunch — forty-two dollars is an unusually low toll for a St. Regis dining room.²

The value play is at Robertson Quay. **Vincenzo Capuano**, the Singapore outpost of the Naples pizzeria, ferments its dough up to **30 hours** and cuts slices with scissors rather than a wheel. Its four-course **"La Vita È Bella" lunch runs \$28 a head, unlimited**. The restaurant holds about **30 per cent of its seating for walk-ins** — a deliberate anti-queue policy, and the most useful fact here. And its own banner calls the chef **"#13 Best Pizzeria in the World"**, which is not what the ranking says: the placing is thirteenth among artisan pizza chains. The pedigree is real; the banner overstates it.³

THE CHATTER · NOBODY HAS EATEN HERE YET

Across Eatbook, SETHLUI, HungryGoWhere, Time Out, Honeycombers, the Michelin guide and Burpple, this desk found **no independent diner review of any of the three rooms above**. What exists is launch material and one round-up calling the Robertson Quay lunch wallet-friendly **"for a pizza this pedigree"**, with no verdict attached. **Too new to call**. If you go this month, you are the review.⁴

THE SCEPTIC · READ THE OPENING HOURS TWICE

Lulu's Lounge on South Bridge Road is a 1930s Shanghai supper club, cabaret and nightclub — jazz and dim sum early, burlesque and DJs late, no cover charge. It is also not quite a new opening: its own page describes a reopening **after six years**, so present it as a relaunch. Then the warnings, all from its own site. The main page gives Monday and Tuesday as 6pm to midnight; its own questions page says those nights are **closed** unless privately booked, and gives different hours for every other day. The postcode differs between the two pages. Booking splits at **11.30pm** — an online system before, a messaging app after. There is an **age limit: women 21 and over, men 23 and over**, a cashless floor, and a **\$50 a head** late-cancellation charge. Sunday brunch is **\$58++**, **\$98++** or **\$128++**. Ring before you go.⁵

Viva Lavender on Lavender Street — European-Asian around a wood-fired grill, with the strongest kitchen pedigree here after the pizzeria, and the fullest price list: hanging tender **\$40**, flat iron **\$42**, miso black cod **\$52**, a three-course set lunch from **\$29++**, and a 1.6kg dry-aged tomahawk at **\$28 per 100g** — a \$448 centrepiece. Every figure rests on a single trade article; the restaurant's own site renders empty. Ring to confirm the cut before you order it.⁶

SOURCES 1 The hotel's own restaurant page, read at source, for the description quoted, the cooking formats, the Champagne price, the set lunch and Sunday table, the opening hours and the absence of an online booking path. The chef's name and the opening date are from trade coverage only and are not on the hotel's page; a separate listing's description of the menu conflicts with the hotel's own and neither is printed as settled. No independent diner review of this restaurant could be found anywhere. 2 The restaurant's own site and the hotel group's own dining directory, read at source, for the room, the regional framing, the chef de cuisine, the two-course set lunch price, the service times and the booking route. No review was found on any local food title or guide. 3 The restaurant's own site, read at source, for the flour, the fermentation, the scissor service, the four-course lunch price and its contents, the walk-in seating policy, the address and the booking routes, and for the banner claim; the ranking it cites places the chef thirteenth among artisan pizza chains, which is the correction made in the text. No verdict has been published by any local title. 4 Searches of the named local food titles and guides on 10–11 October 2026 returned no independent diner review of the first four venues on this page; the quoted phrase is from one food round-up of 1 October 2026 that offers no verdict, and the absence of a filed menu is recorded by a listings site. 5 The venue's own site, read at source, for the concept and programming, the relaunch after six years, the brunch prices, the cancellation charge, the age limit and dress code, the split booking route, and for both sets of opening hours and both postcodes, which contradict each other across its own pages. An opening date implied by a file name on the site is not stated on it and is not printed. 6 A single trade article of 9 October 2026 for the concept, the two chefs' backgrounds and every price quoted; the restaurant's own site returns an empty page to this desk, so none of it is confirmed at source.

THE UNDERCURRENT · JAPAN'S THIRD BEER

For thirty-two years, a tax table wrote the recipes

On 1 October Japan flattened the rates that invented an entire category of drink. Six days later its competition regulators raided all four brewers, and the trade body itself.

The most consequential product designer in Japanese brewing never worked for a brewery. For three decades it sat in the Ministry of Finance, in a table of rates per 350 millilitres, and every time it moved the brewers reformulated. Malt above a line meant ¥77 a can in tax. Below a quarter malt by weight, a drink was **happōshu** and paid ¥46.99. Replace some of the malt with barley spirit and it fell outside beer altogether — ¥28. The industry called the result **新ジャンル**, *shin-janru*, “new genre”; shoppers called it **第三のビール**, third beer. It was not a recipe anyone wanted. It was the shape of a tax notch, filled in.¹

On **1 October 2026** the notches went. All beer-type drinks now pay the same **¥54.25** per 350ml — **¥155,000** per kilolitre. Beer fell **¥9.10**, or 14.4 per cent. Happōshu and new genre rose **¥7.26**, or 15.5. Canned chūhai took its first increase ever, **¥7**. The reform was legislated back in **2017** and delivered in three steps, of which this is the last.¹

What makes it an argument rather than a schedule is the ministry's own stated reason. Its chart says the change was made to correct a situation in which **the rate gaps between similar liquors were affecting product development and sales volumes**, and to restore fairness of tax burden between them, with revenue held neutral. That is a finance ministry writing down, in its own publication, that its tax had been designing the nation's drinks. Few states ever admit this so plainly, and almost nobody outside Japan has noticed that one did.¹

Note what did not happen. Canned chūhai — the spirit-based sours that now occupy much of the shelf the third beer is leaving — rose only to **¥35**, which still sits about **¥19** below the new beer rate. The state flattened one set of notches and left another

standing. If the lesson of the last thirty-two years holds, that is where the next engineered category will appear, and the brewers already know it: every one of them raised chūhai prices on the same morning, and the ready-to-drink lines went up alongside the happōshu.¹

A category born of a tax notch in 2003, legally abolished in 2023, and commercially buried in 2026.

The tax agency's own volume tables show what thirty-two years of this did. Beer ran **7,413 thousand kilolitres** in the 1994 fiscal year. By 2024 it was **2,465** — a fall of **two-thirds**. Over the same span total taxed liquor fell only about **twenty per cent**, from a peak of 10,166 thousand kilolitres to 8,116. The Japanese did not stop drinking. They were moved, can by can, into whichever legal category was cheapest that year.²

The purest illustration is a line in that table called **その他の醸造酒等**, “other brewed liquors”. There was no such line in 2003. In the 2004 fiscal year it appears at **272** thousand kilolitres, climbs past a thousand the following year — and by 2024 it reads **7**. An entire product category, invented by a tax boundary and extinguished inside twenty years, visible in a government spreadsheet as a bump that rises from nothing and returns to nothing.²

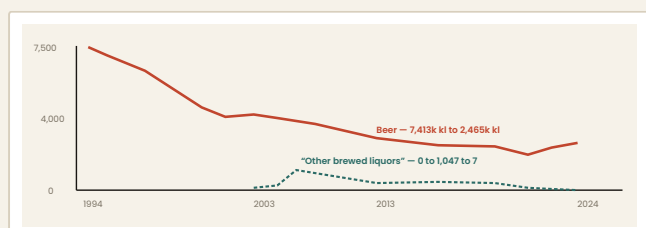
It died twice, in fact. In **October 2023** new genre ceased to be its own bracket and was folded back into happōshu, relabelled **発泡酒②** — happōshu-two — which is why the happōshu line in the same table triples from 586 to 1,927 thousand kilolitres in two years while the liqueur line falls away beneath it. The category was legally abolished three years ago and commercially buried this month.²

SOURCES 1 The Ministry of Finance's own chart of liquor-tax rate revisions, read at source as the ministry's published document: the rates per 350 millilitre equivalent for beer, happōshu, new genre and other sparkling liquors at each step from before October 2020 through October 2026, the unified rate per kilolitre, and the ministry's stated rationale, which is paraphrased here from its own Japanese text. The 2017 legislative origin is confirmed by the brewers' own trade-body release. One precision point, stated here because it is widely got wrong elsewhere: happōshu in the 25-to-under-50-per-cent malt bracket does not move on this date; only the sub-25-per-cent bracket does. 2 The National Tax Agency's own table of taxed liquor volumes, downloaded and parsed from the agency's published spreadsheet for 2026: volumes in thousand kilolitres by legal category and fiscal year, including the beer series from 1994 to 2024, the total liquor series and its 1999 peak, and the rise and disappearance of the “other brewed liquors” category. The agency's column headings are legal classifications rather than shelf categories. The reading that the 2023 swap between the happōshu and liqueur lines reflects the reclassification of new genre is this desk's inference from the table, supported by one brewer's own English release listing its products as “New genre (Happoshu②)”; it is not stated as such by the agency.

So what happens to a market whose entire product architecture was tax-shaped, once the shape is removed? The first three days are in, and they are emphatic. A national supermarket point-of-sale estimate comparing **1 to 3 October** against the same days a year earlier, adjusted for day of week, found beer units **up 19.5 per cent**, happōshu **down 25.6**, and new genre **down 35.1**. Individual lines moved harder still: one brewer's flagship 350ml can rose **57.2 per cent**, another's 500ml **49.4**.¹

Read the week before and the picture sharpens into something less flattering to the policy. In the last days of September, beer units ran **down 17.8, 11.2, 10.8 and 20.1 per cent** on successive days, and September beer overall was down five. Shoppers were not buying less beer; they were waiting for Thursday. And the cheap tier was being hoarded — one supermarket group doubled inventory of the affected lines against the previous year, with case sales from early September running about **one and a half times** the year before. The source of the point-of-sale figures prints its own caveat, and so should we: units, not litres or revenue; three days; and promotions, weather and stockpiling all in play.¹

On the shelf the moves are small and precisely engineered. One national supermarket chain announced on 30 September that its own premium draft beer would go from **¥173 to ¥162** while its budget happōshu line went the other way, **¥129 to ¥137**. A major brewer moved its flagship premium 350ml from an assumed **¥279 to ¥270** and raised its third-beer lines. Another published a producer-price revision in May for deliveries from 1 October: beer down, happōshu up, new genre up, ready-to-drinks up — without publishing a single per-unit figure. Eleven yen here, seven yen there. The entire category architecture of a **¥1.6 trillion** market turns on sums smaller than a bus fare.⁴



SOURCES 1 A commercial retail-measurement firm's rapid national supermarket point-of-sale estimate published 6 October 2026, comparing 1–3 October 2026 with 2–4 October 2025 on a day-of-week-adjusted basis, read at source: the category unit movements, the daily beer figures, the individual product lines and the preceding week's declines. The caveats quoted — units rather than litres or revenue, a three-day window, and the confounding of promotions, weather and pre-reform stockpiling — are the source's own. The inventory and case-sales figures for one supermarket group are from broadcast reporting of September 2026, whose own caveat is that the multiple spans chūhai as well as beer. 2 The National Tax Agency's own taxed-volume table, as cited on the preceding page; the chart is this magazine's, drawn from that table, and the intermediate years between the labelled points are plotted from the same series. 3 Agency reporting of 7 October 2026 on the opening of a criminal cartel investigation into the four brewers over beer-category shipment prices and on the search of the industry trade body; the approximate ninety-per-cent market share is from the same reporting. No findings have been made and none are implied here. 4 Retailer and brewer announcements of 30 September and 4 June 2026 as carried by the Japanese wire, read in syndication, for the shelf and assumed prices quoted; one brewer's own English release of 20 May 2026 for the direction of travel by category, which publishes no per-unit amounts; the approximate market value is attributed by the wire to the tax agency and was not found by this desk in an agency table. Brewer announcements and Japanese trade coverage of 1 and 6 October 2026 for the reformulation of discount brands above the fifty-per-cent malt threshold, the relaunch dates, and the published six-pack price architecture including the new tier. The annual case figure is one outlet's; a differing figure for a different year exists and the two are not presented here as a series.

Taxed volume, thousand kilolitres, fiscal years 1994–2024. A Meridian chart from the National Tax Agency's own published table. The dashed line is the category a tax boundary invented in 2003 and erased by 2024.²

Then the second act, which nobody has joined to the first. On **7 October**, six days after every brewer in Japan repriced its entire range on the same morning, the Japan Fair Trade Commission opened a **criminal** cartel investigation into all four — Asahi, Kirin, Suntory and Sapporo, who between them hold about **ninety per cent** of the market — over beer-category shipment prices. Investigators also raided the **Brewers Association of Japan** itself: not only the companies, but the room where they meet.³

The state removed the tax that coordinated the industry, and six days later asked whether the industry had been coordinating anyway.

The juxtaposition is the story. For thirty-two years the brewers did not need to collude on product architecture, because the tax table did it for them: four companies reading the same notch arrive at the same recipe without a conversation. Remove the table, and every firm must set prices by itself for the first time in a generation — which is also the first moment at which a competition regulator can tell the difference between a cartel and a tax.³

What the brewers are doing with their freedom is, mostly, abolishing the cheap tier by promoting it. All four are lifting malt content above fifty per cent so the discount brands qualify as legal beer. One relaunched its biggest-selling cheap brand **as beer on 6 October**, with a second variant a week later — a brand that sold roughly **thirty million cases** in a year and accounts for about half that company's entire beer-category sales. The same brewer has published a new price architecture with a tier it calls **“daily beer”**, at about **¥880** a six-pack, built precisely where third beer used to stand.⁴

And here is where the policy's own logic fails, in a number the brewers themselves commissioned. Asked what they would drink *instead* of new genre once it became expensive, **56.0 per cent of its drinkers said they would not increase any other alcohol at all**. Ten per cent would move to chūhai, eight to beer, eight to highballs. More than half simply leave.¹

The rest of that survey explains why. People drink beer **“because it tastes good”** — 76.7 per cent give that reason. They drink the cheap tier **“because the price is reasonable”** — 64.1 per cent. Those are not two preferences about flavour; they are a preference and a constraint. Remove the constraint's relief and you do not convert a thrifty drinker into a beer drinker. You convert him into someone who drinks less. And the cheap tier was the heavier habit: 4.7 cans a week against beer's 4.3.¹

Monthly household spending on alcohol at home had already fallen to **¥5,312**, down ¥147 on the year, with **56.7 per cent** saying food inflation had raised their thrift. Asked about a roughly ¥60 rise on a six-pack, **20.8 per cent** of cheap-tier drinkers said they would drink less, rising to **24.3** among those drinking one to four times a week. The reason given, by a majority, was not taste. It was **“because the household budget is getting harder”**.¹

Remove the cheap tier and you do not create a beer drinker. You create an ex-drinker.

A second survey, run for a business magazine a fortnight before the switch, points the same way from a different angle: **27.2 per cent** of people who had bought beer or happōshu in the past year said the reform would push them toward **non-alcoholic** drinks, and about forty per cent of existing non-alcoholic buyers said they would buy more. The two surveys disagree sharply on how many people even knew the change was coming — **61.8 per cent** against **39.0** — which is itself worth knowing before trusting either.²

Both numbers deserve a warning label, and the first deserves the louder one. That survey is

commissioned by the brewers' trade association together with a lobby group whose name translates as the Association to Consider Happōshu Taxation — a body whose entire subject matter ceased to exist on 1 October, and whose purpose is to argue that beer tax is too high. Its free-text tallies read exactly as you would expect: **156** respondents writing “too expensive, please lower it”, against 47 writing “expensive, but it cannot be helped”. Read it as a brief, not a finding. It is still the best panel data anyone has.¹

The counter-argument is real and should be stated. Beer-category volume was falling anyway: down **3 per cent** in the first half of 2026, down **4 per cent** in the same period of 2025, down **7 per cent** in July alone — with the brewers themselves blaming the spread of thrift under rising prices, not tax. One brewer's own executive had already projected the whole beer-type market shrinking about six per cent. On that reading the tax reform is not causing a decline; it is arriving in the middle of one, and the October bounce is a one-month pull-forward that will look like nothing by Christmas. The test is clean, and it comes soon: if the supermarket data for **November and December** hold beer above last year once the stockpiles are drunk, the reform moved people. If beer falls back toward its September trend while the cheap tier stays down, then what the state removed was not a distortion but an affordable floor.³

Which is the argument. A tax designed to stop distorting the market is itself a market intervention of the first order, and a state that spent thirty-two years accidentally writing recipes has spent one morning accidentally writing a price floor. Japan has run the experiment that every finance ministry contemplating “simplification” should read: when the cheap version of a thing exists only because of a tax line, deleting the line does not restore a natural market. It reveals how many people were only ever in the market at the lower price. The brewers will be fine; they have relabelled the cheap brands as beer and invented a tier to hold the gap. The question is whether the drinkers follow, and the first evidence says more than half of them will not.¹

SOURCES 1 The annual home-drinking survey published 1 September 2026 by the Japanese brewers' trade association together with a happōshu taxation lobby group, read at source as the published release and digest: a web panel of 1,200 respondents, fieldwork 1–6 May 2026, mean age 51.2. The substitution question and its 56.0 per cent answer, the stated reasons for drinking each category, the weekly can counts, the monthly spend and its year-on-year fall, the thrift figure, the responses to a hypothetical six-pack increase including the mid-user figure, the stated reason for cutting, and the free-text tallies are all from that publication. Its commissioning bodies are named in the text because they bear on how it should be read. 2 A market-research company's survey for a business magazine, published 17 September 2026 and read at source: the figures for those saying the reform would move them toward non-alcoholic drinks, the figure for existing non-alcoholic buyers, and its own awareness figure. The awareness gap between the two surveys reflects different wording and different fieldwork dates and is reported as contested rather than resolved. 3 Agency reporting of July 2026 carrying the four brewers' own first-half estimates and the July figure, with the brewers' stated attribution to price-driven thrift; the comparable 2025 figure from the same wire a year earlier; and a named brewing executive's published projection of February 2025 for the beer-type market. The falsification test set out in the text is this desk's own.

MERIDIAN

THE LAST WORD

What the toll was for

A Delaware jury went home without deciding what a company may charge for permission to design a chip (p7). A Japanese ministry admitted, in its own chart, that its tax table had been writing the nation's beer recipes for thirty-two years (p25). A watchmaker printed a limit of two hundred and fifty pieces and charged exactly what it charges for the unlimited one (p10). A sock's linked toe, the clearest mark of quality in the category, costs about a dollar (p6).

Each of those is a toll: a sum charged not for a thing but for access to it. What the issue keeps turning up is how rarely the toll matches the thing. The hundred dollars between two Garmins buys a strap and thirty seconds (p9). The cheapest real upgrade in a sport full of thousand-dollar trucks is a set of bushings (p17). And the one bridge on this cover charges nothing at all.

Stevenson, who is on page two, went to the Cévennes with a donkey and no destination. He had worked out the thing this issue keeps circling: that the fee and the journey are different purchases, and most of what we are sold is the fee.

TWELVE DESKS · ONE WORLD

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A note on method. This edition's load-bearing figures were read where they are published: the United States Treasury's own sanctions licence and its daily par yield curve; the Japanese Ministry of Finance's liquor-tax chart and the National Tax Agency's taxed-volume spreadsheet, parsed here; the Japan Meteorological Agency's typhoon and climate normals; Japan's Ministry of Health, Labour and Welfare prefectural life tables; Japan's National Police Agency guidance on foreign driving permits; Singapore's Land Transport Authority news release and its active-mobility handbook, the Civil Aviation Authority's levy tables, the Ministry of Transport's round-up speech, the Health Ministry's written replies, the environment agency's real-time pollutant feeds and its own band tables, and the Bills Supplement text of the Land Transport and Related Matters (No. 2) Bill; the United States Geological Survey's event and loss-estimate services and the National Hurricane Center's advisory; a securities filing for the Micron settlement; TSMC's own monthly revenue page; Shuriyo Castle Park's own reopening notices; two abstract records at the National Library of Medicine; and the makers' own product pages for every price printed. Where a source refused this desk — Reddit to several of our researchers, the airline newsrooms, the Wikimedia image hosts, a pizzeria's ranking claim — it is said so on the page rather than papered over. Figures we could not verify are held, not guessed: no Scoot fare, no Singapore price for the Enduro 4, no hotel rate, no units behind an album chart. Corrections are printed on the desk that erred: this issue corrects our own exchange-rate assumption for TSMC's guidance (p7), and declines to print a correction a researcher proposed, because the archived page was right (p4).